

Run

Eli

How to operate and
grow a small creative agency

Studio

Altman

Run

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**Are you
talking to
me?**

Is this book for you? Since we're just getting underway, now is as good a time as any to make sure we're on the same page. *Run Studio Run* is written for people who have small (3-20-ish person) creative studios, or anyone who aspires to be in this category. The aim of the book is to give small studios the focus, process, and business development tools needed in order to build a thriving small business. *Run Studio Run* is not about how to make better creative work. There are plenty of resources out there for that already. This is all about the brass tacks: responsibilities, goals, delegation, competition, bookkeeping — all of the practical realities of running a small studio.

We will answer questions like:

How many services should I offer?

How do we build processes for the work my team and I do every day?

How do I set goals for my business and my employees?

How should I define the responsibilities of my employees?

Are standard work hours important for my studio?

How can I stop wasting time doing administrative work?

How do I find work I'll be excited about?

Is this project worth my time?

How do I grow the studio without sacrificing quality?

How much should I charge for this project?

How do I develop a portfolio that attracts clients I want to work with?

...and lots more.

This book is not for freelancers, per se, although there are certainly several chapters freelancers will find useful. It is also not for big agencies. Once you reach a certain size (over 20 people or so) the process of retaining culture and cohesion, as well as how you approach things like management, hiring, and human resources, needs to change. Bigger ships make wider turns. *Run Studio Run* is here to help you run a tight ship while you're small — and once you've got that down, you will be on your way to becoming an unstoppable force.

Who is this coming from?

I'm the third generation of my family making a living doing creative work. When I was seven I drew the logo of every single American professional sports team. My grandfather was a painter and interior designer. He designed interiors for Brooklyn mobsters in the '50s. My father was a copywriter on Madison Avenue who founded Altman & Manley, the country's first hybrid ad agency/design studio. He went on to start one of the world's first naming companies, A Hundred Monkeys, which I run today. I graduated from the Design Media Arts program at UCLA, interned at Factor Design, and worked at MetaDesign, San Francisco, as a brand strategist. I developed the naming practice at

Meta before moving on to A Hundred Monkeys in 2009.

When I started at A Hundred Monkeys the business was feast or famine. We'd have banner years followed by lean years where we had to lay people off. Creatively I felt very confident in what we were delivering. Clients liked our work and us. Some even came back for more. As a business however, we had a lot to learn. Our naming process changed from project to project. We didn't have goals, milestones, or clearly defined deliverables. We said yes to almost any project we thought we could execute regardless of whether we were straying outside our area of expertise. When we had lots of work we thought we were brilliant. When it dried up we had no idea where it went. We didn't have processes for sales or client retention. We had no clear division of labor. And yet there we were — a lean, nimble company that had been around since 1990 and survived the tech bubble bursting and the stock market imploding.

My entire professional career I have worked for creative people. And as brilliantly creative as they were, running a business was never the focus. Often there was even a disdain for business: It was a bureaucratic drudgery that took you away from the delicate craft of creative endeavor.

But I wanted to break out of this irregular feast or famine cycle we had been stuck in.

I had no shortage of theories about what was causing the ups and downs. Maybe our specialization was too niche. Maybe a naming company, no matter how successful, could only get to a certain size. But I met with clients every week who ran successful, growing businesses. I was envious. I wanted to run a growing business. At the very least I wanted to run a stable one. So I did the same thing I do whenever I feel like I don't know what I'm doing. I started reading. I read business book after business book. My friend Jeff Hyman, a professor at the Kellogg School of Management at Northwestern University, gave me a great list to get started. I dove into Wikipedia and Investopedia. I listened to small-business podcasts. I happened upon a Cal business school syllabus on the floor of a used bookstore in Berkeley and picked up the books I hadn't read yet. It was addictive. Even though the books were dry and often focused on other industries, I finished every book with specific improvements I could apply at A Hundred Monkeys. Every business book that found its way into my queue felt like potential energy for making the company run smoother and more efficiently.

In 2014 as I started to incorporate these practices and improvements, the business stabilized. In the beginning, there was a ton of data collection but it was easy to see that with some patience it would pay dividends. As we built frameworks around sales and client retention the business started to take off.

As of first publication of this book A Hundred Monkeys has been profitable each of the last 13 quarters and averaged 62 percent year-over-year growth during that same time period. We have roles, processes, and goals with plans to achieve them. And, as always, there's still plenty to improve upon.

I wrote this book because the vast majority of books I've read and resources I've found hadn't been created with the creative community in mind. While some concepts and improvements fit right in, others felt out of place or needed to be adapted. I was surprised to find the ways in which running a creative studio were similar to running a law firm or a startup. I was not surprised to find the ways in which it was different. Workflows, hiring, the ways we interact with clients — all very un-lawyer-like. I wanted to dive into the specifics of what works for creative studios. It took a lot of persistence, consultation, and trial and error to figure out approaches that worked and didn't compromise creativity.

So that's why I wrote this book. I believe that most creative studios can, with a little guidance, run much more profitable businesses. Running a business is a lot like having a brand. You have one whether you like it or not so you might as well put in the work to have a good one. I have included many of the tools and resources we've created and adapted to run A Hundred Monkeys.

Featuring insights from —

I'm confident that the way I run A Hundred Monkeys isn't the only way to run a creative studio. That's why I interviewed 20 creative professionals and studio leaders from around the U.S. and the world. You will see their insights, commentary, and tips in the form of quotes throughout the book.

Christian Schwartz +
Paul Barnes
Commercial Type
New York / London

Aaron Draplin
Draplin Design Co.
Portland, OR

Verónica Fuerte
Hey Studio
Barcelona

JJ Kaye +
Michelle Priest
High Pressure Zone
Los Angeles

Kate Bingaman-Burt
Portland, OR

Patricia Callaway +
Tom Crabtree
Manual Creative
San Francisco

Mikey Burton
New York

Brent Couchman
Moniker
San Francisco

Bobby Martin +
Jennifer Kinon
OCD
New York

Jeff Perky
Perky Bros.
Nashville

Tim Fisher
Scansion
San Francisco

Emily Tu + Ed Ng
Tung
Toronto

Armin Vit +
Bryony Gomez-Palacio
Under Consideration
Bloomington

Jenny Pan
The Weekend Press
Oakland





01

Business muscles

And how to grow them

Look. I'm going to be really blunt here. If you have a creative studio, no matter how small or ad hoc, you are running a business. I know you're passionate about design and just want to be left to your creative ideations, but you can't bury your head in the sand anymore.



There's no escaping the fact that you run a business. Do clients pay you for creative work? Do you pay taxes on the money that you make for that work? Sure you do. Because you run a business and not some bohemian bartering collective.

So then why is it that the majority of creative professionals don't view themselves as business people? My guess is it has something to do with the image that pops into your head when you hear "business people." They wear slacks and have conversations around the water cooler about fantasy football. That's not you. You wear raw denim and drink third wave coffee. It's almost as if being intentional about running a good business would somehow invalidate your creative cred. I'm here to tell you that's total horseshit. You can be a talented creative professional and savvy business person all at the same time. I'll even go one step further and tell you that if you put some real work into building an efficient business, you will actually have more time and energy to commit to your creative work. Did I mention you'll make more money?

YOU DON'T KNOW IF YOU DON'T ASK:

"Don't be afraid to ask stupid questions if you don't know. This is how you learn stuff."

-KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

BRUTAL HONESTY:

“I’m a designer first. Business-wise, let’s get this straight, I certainly don’t have my act together.”

—AARON DRAPLIN, DRAPLIN DESIGN CO.

I get it. I went to design school. I didn’t take a single math class in college. Why bother? I’m never going to use this stuff anyway. While creative work is thought-provoking and exhilarating, figuring out how to run an efficient business feels drab and pedantic. But look how competitive the creative field is. Look at how many solo practitioners there are — how many small studios. If you were to walk into any crowded urban coffee shop and yell “I’m looking for a designer,” half of the people in there would sheepishly look up from their laptops and macchiati wondering why you’re disturbing their flow. Point is, creative professionals are everywhere and you need to take this shit seriously. You’re running a business whether you like it or not — and in a very competitive industry! So, you might as well run a good one.

Building the skills to do so might feel like slogging through the mud. It might feel like taking calculus when you want to be painting. But it's work worth doing if you're looking to survive and grow in a competitive field. Frankly, the work isn't even that difficult. It just takes two things: a consistent commitment to educating yourself (good start picking up this book) and a willingness to experiment while tracking results. We're going to dive deep into both of these things but not just yet. Hold your horses.

Can't I just get someone else to handle the business part? No. This work is too important to offload to someone else. Letting someone else handle the "business side" has been the downfall of countless artists and musicians. Ask Billy Joel. Pretending like you can ignore or outsource the business side of your studio will get you into trouble more often than not. Read books, listen to podcasts, go to conferences. Find a way to make learning about business enjoyable and find a program that you can stick to. On average, I read a business book each quarter and listen to podcasts weekly. I'm not going to lie to you; most business books are pretty boring. Some are poorly written. Some are sexist. Some are poorly written and sexist. Don't let that stop you from extracting the information that's useful to you and shaking your head at the rest. When these books get interesting is when you find things you can apply to your studio. For example, *Managing the*

BE HERE NOW:

“Neither of us have a business background. As we’ve gone along, we’ve met with colleagues and other designers who’ve started their own studios to get their advice on how to get your first clients and how to get yourself out there. If anything, we were looking for mental reassurance that we had made the right decision.”

—EMILY TU, TUNG

Professional Service Firm by David H. Maister (Simon & Schuster, 1993) is a dense, slow read. But its pages are filled with useful and immediately applicable information. It was written for law firms and big consulting firms but creative studios are absolutely professional service firms and there’s a lot we can learn from our suited counterparts.

THERE ARE BUSINESS PEOPLE ALL AROUND YOU:

“It’s good to hang out with other business people. It could be an accountant or a real estate agent. I learn a lot from my contractor even though I hate him.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

One big advantage smaller creative studios have is the ease with which we can implement these changes. Almost every business book I have read has led to specific, positive changes in how we do business at A Hundred Monkeys. For example, we introduced client feedback forms after reading about them in *Managing the Professional Service Firm*. We started with the format the book suggests and modified it as we went, tracking our response rate. Implementing something like this at a big company could take years. We sent out our first requests for feedback within a week and made gradual changes over time. When the response rate to physical mailers started lagging, we switched to online forms. It took literally a day. Easy as that.

So remember: you're a business person. You have no choice in the matter so stop trying to fight it. No one is going to force you to wear pleated pants. This does not make you any less brilliantly creative. So now that we're square on that, let's figure out what your studio needs to focus on.

02

Focus, dammit

Stop trying to do everything

If you're struggling to keep the lights on, it's understandable that you're going to want to chase every project that comes across your desk. The problem is, this lack of focus will ensure that there will always be competitors who have better skills and more experience than you do.



If you have a general menu of services, or worse, no defined services at all, you're turning your work into a commodity. Logos? Yeah, we do logos. Websites? Yeah, we do websites. Apps? Totally, we make apps.

Think about it. If you're casting such a wide net that you're competing with half of the creative field, what sets you apart? How will a client know when to call you instead of any other creative firm they might have heard of? More importantly, how are you going to be truly great at all of that stuff at the same time? How are you going to deliver work that makes your client say, "Wow, I'm a genius for hiring you"? When you say yes to everything, you become just another vendor (as clients like to call collaborators they don't see a ton of value in). How do people pick between vendors? Simple: cost.

Focus doesn't mean that you have to be Charlie Chaplin in *Modern Times*, doing the same quarter turn with a crescent wrench a thousand times a day. You'll be amazed at how much nuance and variation can be found within a focused business.

Have you seen the documentary *Jiro Dreams of Sushi*? Jiro Ono has made sushi just about every day of his life for half a century yet he's still inventing, still improving. He has the Michelin stars to prove it and he's still going. So don't tell me that having a focus is going to hem you in. That's nonsense.

FOCUS BEGETS CONFIDENCE:

“I don’t have to explain what we do to people anymore. People get it. This is a crowning achievement. For companies that are struggling to define themselves, clients can pick up on that and read that and hear it in meetings. Being able to clearly define who you are and what you do gives you confidence.”

“Creating OCD wasn’t an easy decision. I had to leave Pentagram, Bobby had to leave London. The reason we made the jump was focus. We wanted to develop big identity systems for big companies. We just have a love of systems. They don’t come to you asking for a system — there aren’t that many companies out there looking for a total system overhaul. You need to put that out into the world before it’s something that people know they want.”

Having a clear focus will benefit all aspects of your business. Anyone who interacts with you or your site or any work you've done will have a clear understanding of what you're good at and when a project is a good fit for you. Your proposals will stand out because you will have loads of relevant experience and will be able to speak intelligently with the client about their business. You will run into all the problems that you could possibly run into and figure out easy ways to avoid them. Your work process will be smooth and efficient because you've done projects like these before and know what they entail and how long they take. Clients will be able to refer you to new clients because they have friends in similar businesses that have similar needs. You will start to build a profitable little ecosystem.

A Hundred Monkeys has taken several forms over the years. We've said yes to identity design projects and full rebrands. We've built websites. We even acted as outside creative directors for an airline for three years. While it's nice to feel wanted, these projects were a massive waste of our time. It's not that we couldn't do these things. We could. We did. It's that we weren't experts at them.

THIS IS FOCUS:

“We stumbled upon the idea of being a printer with a design background. We asked a lot of designers about printers and there was a sense that a lot of them weren’t so approachable and we found that interesting. We used that to have a different angle. Peter had an apprenticeship as a printer earlier in his career. We wanted to bridge the design and print communities — to be a printer who understood designers.”

—JENNY PAN, THE WEEKEND PRESS

We had only built a few websites. If a seasoned web designer watched our process they would have pulled their hair out or much worse. Our inexperience in these areas cost us time and money. Not anymore. A Hundred Monkeys is a naming company. We name companies, products, services, product architectures. We’re all writers, so we grew into doing brand stories and positioning for our existing clients. We never touch design. We never touch code. And we’re better off for it — as are our clients. Designers and other creative agencies can

partner with us without wondering if we're going to poach their clients. We have our processes down and are prepared to say no when a project strays from our expertise.

A lot of people are so eager to get work that they're willing to say yes to about anything. This means they're doing a ton of bespoke projects and reinventing the process every time they get a yes. This is a victimless crime if you're working on your own but if you're working on a team, trying to grow a business, this is probably the biggest hindrance to your success. Even if you are working on your own you will quickly run into the limit of your available time. Sure, you can charge more for your services, but unless you plan on working like a rented mule for the rest of your career, you might want to figure out a support system that allows you to spend as much time as possible doing what you're truly great at.

Your focus could be on a deliverable, an industry, a client size, an objective goal — something you are excited about and know well. Focus on something you can be great at — something you can charge a premium for because you're that good at it. Be specific. "Providing innovative strategies that meet and exceed the needs of our clients" is not a focus. It's marketing rhetoric. Your focus should be narrowing. "Developing visual design systems for small teams looking to make a big impact" is a focus. So what is it? What's your focus?

03

**You want it,
we've got it**
Fine-tuning
your offering

Nice restaurants have short, well-curated menus. The Cheesecake Factory's menu is literally a bound book with a few hundred items and ads for "laser liposuction." If you want people to value your work, you need to slim down your offering.



With a big menu of services, everything becomes harder. It's harder to track hours, it's harder to apply what you've learned from past projects to new projects, and it's harder for clients to figure out what they're looking for. You need a lot of repetition to be great at something — to find efficiencies, to recognize and fix flaws. Focus your offering so you can track results, iterate on process, and fine-tune all the variables until you have your process down cold.

GET DEEP:

“Bobby and I have both worked in-house. We built OCD to work like a bunch of SWAT teams that can virtually embed with our clients. Systems projects tend to be long term; we get close.”

“The downside of abundant choice is that each new option adds to the list of trade-offs, and trade-offs have psychological consequences. The necessity of making trade-offs alters how we feel about the decisions we face; more important, it affects the level of satisfaction we experience from the decisions we ultimately make.”

**“I fear not
who has p
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kicks once
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kick ten t
times.”**

the man
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housand

What you offer says a lot about your agency. It should, by design, exclude people who wouldn't be good clients for you. While having a focused offering can feel unnecessarily limiting at first, it ensures that every project you work on works for you.

What do I mean by this? If you're working on projects that you're excited about and can confidently execute, everything you spend your time on will be simultaneously building a portfolio, client base, and referral base of similarly exciting projects that you can confidently execute. You know how they say, "Dress for the job you want, not the job you have"? The same applies here. Tailor your offering to the portfolio and clients you want.

KNOW WHAT YOUR CLIENTS REALLY NEED:

"We need to do lots of listening and some translation to understand what our clients need, what their expectations are and where those things intersect, or more importantly where they don't. A big part of this process is understanding in-house capabilities. You're never going to get all the information you need from one phone call."

CONNECT YOUR OFFERINGS:

“The unique thing about our company is that it’s two kinds of businesses tied together. Making custom fonts and then retail licensing. A lot of the retail fonts we’ve released started out as custom.”

—PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

As a small agency, you should, at most, have three offerings that you can work to constantly improve and streamline.

These offerings should feed off each other so you can turn your existing clients into repeat clients. This is what we did at A Hundred Monkeys by growing into more writing work. If your core business is identity design, you could offer style guides and iconography. If your core business is portrait photography, you could offer styling and makeup. Your offerings should exist at the intersection of what your clients already need and what you can confidently deliver. Make it concise and easy to explain. Remember, more neighborhood bistro than Cheesecake Factory.

04

Step and repeat

Process is your
new best friend

Process is the most important element of running a small creative firm. It's probably the most important element of running any business, period.



Process makes sure team members know what to do next. Process lets you go on vacation and know that work will still get done. When was the last time you did that? Process ensures that presentations don't have typos. You are your process and as a business owner the more time you can spend teaching and improving your process instead of actually doing the work, the more you'll be able to grow and improve. Make process central to everything you do.

This doesn't just apply to the process of executing client work; it applies to hiring and training and accounting and almost everything else you spend your working hours on. When you have a process, you don't need to reinvent the wheel every time something new happens. You likely won't even have to discuss it. You have a foundation that you can reference and build on. Get in the habit of fixing recurring issues permanently. Don't just fix things when they break down. Fix them so that everyone knows exactly what to do next time to make sure the breakdown doesn't happen in the first place. Don't problem fix. Problem solve.

It's good to start with the broad strokes but you want to end up at a fairly granular level. Now I can hear you saying that this will stifle your creativity. Hah. Please. Creativity demands structure and limits to play off of. Process is not your work, it's the scaffolding around your work, and it can always be improved. For example, at A Hundred Monkeys our naming

project process outline (as of first publication) is 28 steps on 21 pages. This is a living document. We revisit it every three months or so to make sure it accurately reflects how we execute projects. When you're new to the team and working on your first project this is your life preserver. Every time someone is newly hired or confused or encountering a new scenario, they have something to fall back on. The simple act of creating and updating this document saves me countless emails and messages every day.

STARTING OFF ON THE RIGHT FOOT:

“We try to use the same approach and process for every project. We start with a questionnaire, then develop a brief together. Next we do a mood board, then a proposal. Sometimes we send more than one option. Then they choose. Since we're small, everyone pitches in.”

Build a clear, step-by-step process for each of your core offerings.

Build a process for anything else you need to return to on a regular basis. This could include Accounts Receivable, tax prep, employee reviews, hiring. Don't go into painstaking detail at first — you'll get there — just commit the key points to paper (or Google Drive or Dropbox or wherever) and then flesh it out the next time you revisit the process. The time after that, use your process document as a guide, or have someone new to the process attempt to use the guide to complete the process. Make improvements and notations until the process can be done to your satisfaction with limited personal involvement. Remember, every hour you aren't spending in the trenches on this stuff is an hour you could be spending doing creative work — or learning the difference between bison and buffalo. Up to you.

Having a well-defined process makes scoping projects easy. Anything outside your process is easily recognizable as outside of scope.

A clearly defined process means you can clearly articulate it both within your studio and with clients. If everyone can see the results of the process and the specific steps it takes to get there, clients will be less likely to get lost in the woods.

At A Hundred Monkeys we begin every presentation with a visual map of our process that has a big “you are here” arrow. We implemented this when we realized at the end of presentations, we had a lot of clients asking about what happens next. It’s not that we didn’t like answering the question, it’s that if everyone is clear on process at the beginning of the presentation, they’re free to dig into the creative work without thinking about deadlines and calendars.

SAME SAME BUT DIFFERENT:

“It takes time to draft a good proposal. We try to systematize that as much as possible and make it something that’s easy to ship out. A certain level of customization is necessary but we just try to limit where and when we’re customizing.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

“Changing our space actually changed our process where now we can have really productive sessions away from the desk and computer. We used to work over each other’s shoulders. We were more ad hoc. As our calendars have gotten more busy we’ve had to formalize more aspects of our process.”

If you're looking for experts at process, look no further than franchises. For what they lack in originality and locally sourced ingredients, franchises like McDonald's and Subway have two key benefits: they have recognizable brands and they provide consistent experiences. Both of these benefits are the result of clearly defined processes.

While starting your own sandwich shop from scratch would most certainly be more fun, you're doing everything for the first time. Do you bake bread or buy it? How long can you refrigerate turkey before your Yelp reviews start to include the phrase "bathroom emergency"? You need to figure out everything. Now, I don't go to Subway or Quiznos often, but when I do, I know what to expect. These businesses are successful because they have clearly defined processes for everything they do. This allows them to get bigger without compromising their end product. While I imagine you don't have too much interest in becoming the Quiznos of Graphic Design or the Subway of Brand Strategy, it's easy to see that having clearly defined processes that everyone at your company can reference is essential to growing your business.

If you're ever looking to sell your business, it's worth noting that process-driven businesses sell for more. Why? It's simple: they can be run without your personal involvement on a daily basis. Put yourself in your potential acquirer's shoes. What's the point of spending a lot of money to buy a company if it's clear that company loses most of its value once you, the creative force behind the business, are gone? At the very least in these situations, the company acquiring you will tie your buyout to hitting milestones over time that will ensure you work like a rented mule for them and that if they're not making money on your acquisition, you aren't either. Those golden handcuffs aren't looking so golden anymore, are they?

If you run a process-driven business, your personal, day-to-day involvement is less essential. You've shown that the company can run without you, so why should your new overlords force you to stick around? It's also worth noting that process-driven businesses with low customer concentration sell for much more. Low customer concentration means that you aren't overly reliant on one or two big clients for the bulk of your revenue. You're diversified, which is seen as less risky. Now, I don't want to oversimplify the complex process by which creative agencies get bought and sold. Just know that running a process-driven business is good for your company whether you're trying to sell it eventually or not. Try to build a sixth sense for when the work going on in

your studio isn't being guided by an established process. Look for clues like people asking frequent questions or sharing work that's clearly incomplete. Take these signs as clues that your process needs work.

YOU'RE ON THE CLOCK:

“You only have a finite amount of time to create creative work. On a long enough time scale everyone dies, including your clients. The process is there in the service of creating the maximum creative output within your timeframe.”

05

Write your wrongs

Improving and
updating process

You aren't going to get it all right the first time. Look for indicators of success with your process. This could be anything from the amount of time it takes for a certain action to get completed, to finishing a task without your personal involvement.



You need a vision for where you would like all of this to end up. It's important to step back here. We prefer to test processes on smaller projects and projects with clients that have worked with us before — lower-risk situations. Try it on a pro bono project first, if that makes you more comfortable.

LOOK IN THE REARVIEW MIRROR:

“We really believe in the ‘make a plan and expect it to change’ philosophy. We’re both process-oriented people. It is easy to think that process is always good but there’s a danger of focusing too hard on process and getting too involved with it at the cost of the actual work. If you’re less process-oriented in general, formalizing more of the process can be really helpful. The biggest thing for us has been trying to do something and then actually taking the time to reflect on what the fuck we just did. You could just sit down and think about how you actually want to do it but it might turn out different. Taking the time to reflect and adjust, and actually write it down, is everything.”

ZOOM IN, ZOOM OUT:

“It’s a balance of setting constraints and then asking yourself if you’ve created too many boundaries to allow the work to flow. Am I stuck because I’m too fixated on the big picture and I’m not seeing the details, or am I stuck because I’m too fixated on the details and zoom out to see what it means? You need to go back and forth between micro and macro.”

JJ KAYE, HIGH PRESSURE ZONE

Have your team work through the steps you have outlined and see where they get caught up. See where they deviate from what’s on paper. When these meanderings occur, don’t jump in right away. Wait until you get to a logical check-in point and then discuss what parts of the process are working and what parts aren’t. Ask questions and resist the temptation to try and fix everything yourself.

This is important because not only are you teaching people the process, you're teaching them how to diagnose and fix problems in the process on their own. If you jump in every time something goes slightly awry, people won't develop their own sense of what feels right and wrong. They'll just wait for you to jump in. Oftentimes the deviations that people make while trying to work through the process end up getting incorporated later. For example, early on at A Hundred Monkeys, project leaders were in charge of finding images for their presentations. When we got busy this responsibility shifted, out of necessity, to our office manager. Finding images was somewhat of an annoyance for project leads but it was a new and exciting responsibility for our office manager. They got to have hands-on involvement with the creative team and shaped the work that made it in front of clients. With a little instruction the quality of images being selected stayed where it needed to be and we formalized the change.

**“When you
get asked
for help,
diagnose
the problem
and fix your
system so
the problem
doesn’t
recur.”**

—JOHN WARRILLOW

DISTANCE HAS ITS PERKS:

“Working across the Atlantic has been really successful for us. In some ways the distance is helpful. We don’t spend all day being reactive, talking about little things, and leaving a lot of unfinished business. Our phone conversations force us to focus on what we need to talk about and check things off the list.”

—CHRISTIAN SCHWARTZ, COMMERCIAL TYPE

Another small process adjustment we made at A Hundred Monkeys was defining what’s expected of people when they get lost and aren’t sure what they’re supposed to do next. The easiest thing to do is to just raise your hand and say, “I’m lost. What should I do next?” The problem is that this sets up the wrong dynamic. The first reaction to finding yourself in a bind shouldn’t be finding someone else to get you out of it.

Here's the adjustment we made: if you find yourself stuck and needing help from someone else on the team, you need to bring them your recommended course of action — what you would do if there was no one around to help. This shows the person you're asking that you've spent time on the problem.

Often through the process of figuring out the best course of action you end up solving it for yourself and avoid having to rope-in anyone else at all.

Don't waste a bunch of time trying to build the perfect process. This isn't about perfect. It's about good enough. It's easy to find yourself paralyzed, trying to fine-tune every aspect of your processes. This is a waste of time because process changes over time. Make the decision and move on. If you find that something isn't working, change it. The solution might not be perfect but as long as it's better than what you were doing before, you're headed in the right direction. Get the big stuff right and the details will fall into place if you keep working through your process. Do not get stuck here.

06

Goaltending Goals and how to hit them

As with most things in life, if you don't have a clear idea of what you're looking to accomplish, it'll be impossible to know if you ever get there.



Even if you're very successful it's easy to be overtaken by workaholism. There's always the siren call of "you can do better" no matter what you've just achieved. In 2015 we had our most successful year to date at A Hundred Monkeys, doubling our revenue from our previous year. It's hard to take a short vacation over the holidays and then start building from zero revenue again the next year. This is why having clear goals becomes very important.

GET YOUR PRIORITIES STRAIGHT:

“We don’t rely on a local economy to do what we do. We can do it from anywhere. The blogs can exist anywhere; the conference doesn’t rely on where we live. We just need a decent airport and wifi. A lot of people get overly attached to their situation. When we shared that we were moving to Bloomington, a lot of people responded saying, ‘I wish I could do that.’ Well, you can...”

“...People get so caught up in where they are, whether it’s living in New York or something else. It’s about setting priorities and living by them. Some goals are tied to location or environment and some are not.”

-BRYONY GOMEZ-PALACIO, UNDER CONSIDERATION

Not all goals are created equal.

There are three main goals that should guide you here. The first is simple. Profit. Unless you’re playing with other people’s money, profit is the single most important goal for any business. It is also a useful number because it factors in the size of your business. You could have a bustling 40-person studio that brings in \$6 million a year in revenue. Sounds pretty impressive. However, having employees is expensive, especially once you factor in benefits, unemployment, payroll taxes, and everything else. This impressive-looking studio could end up looking very unimpressive when compared to a lean, mean studio of five people bringing in a much more manageable \$2 million a year.

Here's how:

	A, Inc.	B, Inc.
Revenue	6,000,000	2,000,000
Employees	40	5
Payroll	3,600,000	500,000
Other Expenses	300,000	50,000
Partners	4	2
Profit	2,100,000	1,450,000
Profit/Partner	550,000	725,000

*90,000 average salary for A
100,000 average salary for B

*A has a bigger office, and
generally more experience

Looking at the numbers, company A makes 300 percent the revenue of company B but only ends up with 45 percent more profit. That's more projects, more oversight, more sales, more responsibility for not that much more money. If partners are splitting profits, company B ends up distributing \$175,000 more per partner. So the partner at company A looks like a big shot with \$6 million in revenue, 40 employees, and a DWR-laden office. All the while, the lowly partner at company B with only five employees takes home \$175,000 more money pre-tax. Let that sink in for a minute.

Yes, these numbers are just for illustrative purposes, but this goes to show that running a big business doesn't necessarily mean it's a more profitable one. Setting a profit goal evens the playing field. Pick a profit goal for the year. This requires knowing your operating expenses. If you have a bookkeeper and/or accountant, ask them for this information. They will likely be able to sit down with you and work collaboratively with you to establish financial goals. If you don't have an accountant or bookkeeper I'm going to force you to get one in Chapter 20, so might as well get a jump on that one.

I find that it's important to break yearly financial goals into quarterly financial goals. It can be hard to see how one client or one project will help you meet a yearly goal.

The jump is too big. Breaking everything down into quarters gives you perspective on the value of a given project or client. You will be able to ask yourself simple questions like, “If I had four projects just like this one before the end of the quarter, would we hit our quarterly goal?” If you hit your quarterly goals, your yearly goal will take care of itself.

Sometimes settling on a goal can be difficult. How do you know if you’re being too aggressive or too conservative? First, err on the side of being aggressive. It’s deflating to set an easy goal, reach it early in the year, and coast to the finish line. Your goal needs to be something you can strive toward achieving. It should put you in a position to say, “What else can I do to hit that number?” If you haven’t set profit goals before look at how much you’ve made in your best year or calculate what you would be happy with in your bank account at the end of the year.

The second goal is more qualitative and requires some pondering. What would your business need to look like in order to hit your first goal? Can you accomplish this with the team you currently have? How many projects would you need to take on? Would you need a new office? Write down, in as much detail as you can, what your business will look like while attaining your first goal. It might take a few years to reach this goal. That’s OK. If it looks like that’s the case, break this goal down into achievable steps with smaller timeframes. Remember to factor in

REMEMBER YOU WORK FOR A REASON:

“When I had 10 grand I could survive. When I had 20 grand I could pay off everything, credit cards, school loan. When I had 100 grand I paid off my mortgage insurance, my house. I got to zero in 2012. I was spending everything I was making to get out of the hole. If my mom needs help, I’ve got her covered. It’s peace of mind. You can’t put a price on it. These are the things that matter to me. I’m not trying to build my name. They think I’m bigger than I am.”

growing salaries, rents, or any other expenses that grow over time.

The third and final goal is more personal. What would you like your personal involvement in your business to be one and five years from now? As your business grows, your role in nurturing its growth will need to evolve. If you're spending your days the same way as your business grows you're likely turning yourself into a bottleneck, limiting the growth of your business and frustrating the people you work with.

GREENER GRASS AND WHERE TO FIND IT:

“When you start you always yearn for success and size. Then when you start to get big you yearn for the beginning.”

-PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

“If your business depends on you, you don’t own a business — you have a job.”

—MICHAEL GERBER

As your business grows you likely should shift your involvement from operational to strategic. Put another way, you should be working on your business, not in your business. Your job is to create a thriving business system, not to personally win and execute every project that comes your way. What’s the point of becoming more successful if it means that you become a victim of your success, working even harder than you were when your business was fledgling? Write down how you want to be involved in your business when it reaches its ideal state. Again, break this down into achievable milestones. When goals are large and abstract it becomes really difficult to figure out how to get to them. Breaking down big goals into shorter-term milestones helps you connect what you’re doing today and this quarter to what you’re looking to accomplish down the road. A good goal should break down into smaller milestones that you can concentrate on short-term. You also feel a sense of accomplishment when you hit your milestones which builds momentum as you look toward your next milestone.

BREAK IT DOWN:

“When we first started High Pressure Zone we sat down and asked each other where we wanted to be in 10 years. Is this a lifestyle company? Do we even want to be running this company in 10 years? If not, what does an exit look like? Figuring this stuff out allowed us to work backward and figure out what we needed to do now to get there. We had to make sure that as partners we knew what each other wanted to get out of it. As you break that down into smaller and smaller goals, you figure out what you need to do annually and quarterly.

Our most important goals are quarterly and based around objectives and key results. If you have more than three objectives it becomes more of a task list. We definitely believe in ‘what gets measured gets managed.’ In the beginning we were focused a lot more on our offering, our process, our culture. The second year for us was more about figuring out who we wanted our clients to be. This year our focus was on sales. How many leads are we getting? What are our revenue targets? All of this is in service of our 10-year goal.”

I can hear you saying, “I have no idea where my business will be in five years, let alone one year!” To this I say, success will never be good enough unless you can define what it means for yourself.

CELEBRATE YOUR WINS:

“It’s really easy as a young company to just say, ‘We need to do all of the work.’ If we finish something early, we need to start on what we’re supposed to do next week. If you’re sleeping that means you have less time to work on the business. You need to feel good about reaching your goals and feeling good about what you’ve accomplished. There’s always more to do. Make sure you don’t get overwhelmed by what’s next. No one else is going to give you that pat on the back.”

This is why goals are so crucially important. Every year you will have an opportunity to tweak and modify your goals. You might be ahead of schedule or behind schedule. If you're behind schedule, that's OK! At least you have a schedule. Then you can think hard about what you can do to get back on schedule. And when you reach your goals, you will feel fulfilled because you set a goal, made a plan to achieve it, and saw it through. Earning the same amount of money without setting the goal and the plan to get there wouldn't feel half as good. As Lewis Carroll said, "Any road will get you there, if you don't know where you are going."

Most importantly, write your goals down and keep them in a place where you have to see them on a regular basis. I put my goals up where I keep my keys. Research by Dr. Gail Matthews at Dominican University in California found that you are 42 percent more likely to achieve goals that you write down. It takes two minutes and can dramatically affect the likelihood of reaching your goals. Write them down. Put them in a place where you can see them. Do it right now. I'll wait.

07

Who are you looking at?

Developing clear roles
and responsibilities

At its simplest, responsibilities are about knowing who does what. It's important that everyone at your studio has clearly defined roles and responsibilities. If you asked people who work for you to write down everything they're responsible for, do you think they could do it?



Better yet, do you think you could clearly articulate what everyone on your team is responsible for? Hell, it might even be tough to define what you personally are responsible for. Ambiguity around responsibility wastes time, makes people question their value to the studio, and causes your process to stall out. So let's sort through it.

Create a simple chart outlining the big picture of who on your team is responsible for what. If there are only two of you, you will probably have two pretty long lists (someone has to take out the trash and wash the coffee cups, and that someone is probably you). Only be as granular as it is necessary for people to clearly know what they're responsible for. When you hire someone make sure you have an understanding of which responsibilities are going to be migrating over to your new hire's list. If everyone is clear about what work falls under their aegis, you're showing people how they fit into the studio and what they can do to contribute to its overall success.

When you have a team, even a tiny one, there will always be more to do than time to do it. Same goes for life in general. This is why you want to make sure that your high-value employees are doing high-value activities and that everyone in your studio is prioritizing their highest value activities.

Let's break that down.

PUT CRITICISM IN ITS PLACE:

“Christian is really good at doing roman typefaces and I’m really good at doing italics. We may have had a slight argument once but I don’t even remember what it was about. It’s important to take criticism seriously but not personally. We’re all just trying to get the work to where it needs to be.”

–PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

**High-value activities for
high-value employees:**

This means that your most experienced and most capable team members should be working on the things that they’re uniquely qualified to be doing. They should be doing the work that anyone less experienced than them would have trouble doing well. For example, say you have someone running business development for your studio. They’re currently the lowest person on the totem pole who can confidently handle new business calls with potential big clients — no small task. This is their highest value activity. This means that they should almost always prioritize this work over anything else that comes up in the studio. Maybe they schedule a 30–60-minute slot in the afternoon to handle the day’s busy work that always seems to appear out of nowhere.

On a more granular level, which is the most important aspect of business development: writing and reviewing proposals or having calls and meetings with potential clients? It's the latter — calls and meetings with potential clients. Why? Proposals can be drafted and revised and delivered when they're ready. Real-time communication requires full attention, careful listening, and reading between the lines. If you had to teach a junior employee to build

ENOUGH IS ENOUGH:

“Asking a junior designer to manage and guide clients in addition to creating outstanding work is just too much to ask.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

proposals or discuss project needs with a client, which would be quicker and easier to teach? Which is a lower-risk environment to learn? Right, proposals. So, if this business development person is on their own, they can prioritize the calls and meetings with clients and block off some time later to build proposals. If they have junior employees who can help them out, they would be well served to teach the junior employee how to build proposals with your input on specific project needs. That way the more experienced (hopefully better paid) employee is prioritizing the work they're best suited to doing while gradually taking a simpler, lower-value component of the process and offloading it to someone junior for whom it's a higher value activity and a skill-building learning experience.

When you're running a small studio, it's inevitable that people will wear multiple hats. If people do multiple roles, acknowledge it. Try to limit the roles that fall into an ambiguous "We sort of handle that together whenever we need to" territory. It's always fine to discuss these things with other people in the studio. It's even OK to include them in the decision making. Just make sure you know who's responsible and who has final say. Ambiguity about responsibility always leads to things falling between the cracks. So, if you're the creative director and also in charge of finance, that's OK. Write it down on your responsibilities chart. This will become key to your growth plan.

Grow people's responsibilities by looking at your and other key employees' activities and then pass responsibilities on starting at the bottom of the list. As in the business development example just outlined, it's important to see this as growing the skills of a junior studio member, not offloading shit work from a senior employee's desk. There is value in all of the work at a studio. To a lot of people, just being in the creative environment is valuable. Help junior people see the value in their contributions.

In order to pass down responsibility, it becomes important to understand how you're spending your time. A useful approach is to catalog your time in 30-minute increments.

There are multiple ways to do this, including time tracking apps, simple spreadsheets, or even a notepad. From there, examine what makes the most sense to pass down and who makes the most sense to take on the new responsibility. Some of these responsibilities should be covered in detail in your process documents (discussed in Chapter 4). Train people and set them up to succeed. Have check-ins until everything is done to your satisfaction, checking in less frequently as the work you're reviewing becomes better.

If you feel like you can't grow the responsibilities of the people on your team there's one of two problems: either you're doing a bad job of clearly explaining what you're looking for and

BUILD CORE SKILLS:

“These people aren’t going to be working with me forever (although I wish they would). I’m under no illusions. Maybe they want to be a creative director or start their own place, but managing projects and selling work is something you’re going to need to be good at.”

-JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

actually letting others take the responsibility off your shoulders, or you aren’t hiring the right people. Either way, this is your fault. Sorry. Someone had to tell you.

Recruitment and process are both the responsibilities of company leaders. Either develop a stepwise plan to train employees on new skills or find employees who have the skills and motivation. The most common issue I see is leaders telling people they want something done but not actually handing over the responsibility. People need to feel like they fully own something to take responsibility for it.

As a leader, you have the responsibility to figure out when to check in and work toward checking in less frequently (or, even better, not at all). Micromanaging is a hard habit to break but it's absolutely essential. I know you want it done a particular way. If you can't clearly articulate that to someone else, you've got a problem. All this does is create a bottleneck where all work needs to get through you to get in front of clients. People won't do their best work because they know you'll take it over at some point and make it the way you want it. Don't become a limiting factor to your studio's growth.

Giving someone an assignment has three distinct components:

Get the ask right:

Clearly state what you're asking for. Pay attention to the language you're using. Are you clearly articulating what you're asking for? The majority of times I'm reviewing work that I'm not happy with, I realize that I could have more clearly articulated what I was looking for. The point isn't to sound like a cool, easygoing boss/friend. The point is to make sure that both participants in the conversation know exactly what's being asked for. People aren't mind readers. Use examples, be direct, don't mince words. Make sure you create an environment where it's OK for them to ask questions if they're unsure about something.

Define an endpoint:

When would you like to check in on progress? If this is the first time you're giving someone this type of task, set a shorter-term check-in, say, end of day. As you solidify your process and your assignments become routine, you should be checking in less frequently with the confidence that the person you assigned the task to knows what they're doing and knows how to deal with issues should they arise. Pay close attention to when you set your check-ins. If they work well, use the same structure for new employees. If the work isn't up to standard, speak with the person, ask questions to understand if there was a miscommunication, and set a closer goal for next time.

“We’ve done a pretty good job of realizing when we need a person to take a role over. The first person I ever hired was an admin person who could take over invoicing and scheduling with clients. Probably the most important person we have is our font technician who takes what we build and turns them into actual fonts. This was originally part of my role but Mark is so much better at it than I could ever hope to be. You need to recognize when it’s the right time to bring someone else in.”

Calendar a time for review:

“Check in when you’re ready” sounds confident and casual when you say it but it’s ambiguous and counterproductive. Give people a specific time to check in on progress and commit it to the calendar. I generally have the person doing the work send me an invite for a five- or 15-minute check-in at the agreed upon milestone and time. Agree on the time together to make sure it works for both of you and that your employee is given enough time to do the work. Putting the check-in on the calendar provides some extra accountability.

If you put in the work to clarify roles and responsibilities you will save yourself and your studio a lot of time. People will know what they’re on the hook for and where everyone else fits in. A weak link at any point in this chain will make your car run like a Jaguar from the ‘80s, which is to say, unreliably. Honing roles and responsibilities will give your studiomates purpose, clear expectations and clearer deadlines. This allows you to operate more efficiently. What you do with the added time and headspace you gain is up to you. Take on more projects. Work on skill building. Rebuild a horribly unreliable Jaguar from the ‘80s. You choose.

08

Never be late again

Work hours are
so yesterday

The 9-to-5 workday
is a vestige from a
time long before
the internet and
personal computing.
It has limited use
today, especially in
the creative field.



Given the communication and productivity tools available to us, having everyone show up by nine and giving them stern warnings for being late puts your focus in the wrong place and doesn't lead to any meaningful productivity gains. Plus it makes you look like a prick.

A Swedish initiative found that moving to shorter work days (eight hours to six) led to increased productivity, lower turnover, and increased creativity. I'm not telling you to reduce your hours (although we did and it's working great). I'm telling you that in order to get the most out of your studio and the people in it, you need to be flexible and willing to experiment with work hours. Some people are more productive in the mornings; some are more productive in the evenings. Some people can't be productive if they know that they're paying to have someone watch their kids while they work late. Since most people work 9-to-5, rush hour exists. Most grocery stores are packed at six. If you can find a way to be asynchronous with the rest of the working world you can make big productivity gains just by doing things at different times than everyone else.

If you run a process-based studio, then clocking in on time shouldn't even approach your top five ways to tell if an employee is being productive. Are their clients happy? Do they meet their goals? Do they help the business grow? How many projects are they capable of working on?

Measure your employees by what they accomplish and how they fit into the team. It's better for everyone that way.

FIND YOUR BALANCE:

“If a deadline is coming up, we might end up working extra hours. These days I work after I put my daughter to bed. She’s only five months old so I’m still figuring it out. That’s been the biggest struggle for me: finding that balance. Making sure the company is running well and spending time drawing type. It’s a week-by-week and project-by-project challenge.”

IT'S YOUR TIME:

“We manage our time very well. We don’t work late hours. We don’t accept extra clients we know we don’t have the time for. We have a team meeting on Monday and give assignments. Everybody has the capacity to manage their own time as long as they hit our deadlines.”

While clocking-in isn't important, punctuality is very important. If you have a meeting or a call or a presentation you need to be confident that your team will be there, ready and prepared. Just because clients can run late, doesn't mean you can, too. This is a service business and that's bad service. If you're willing to be more relaxed about when the work day starts and stops, employees should understand that you will be exacting about being on time. If this means that you need to schedule some early morning meetings, so be it. At A Hundred Monkeys, anything from 8-to-5 is fair game. People won't schedule anything at eight unless they have to but there's an expectation that if, for whatever reason, we have something on the calendar at eight, people need to be awake and ready by then. Try coffee. It's good stuff.

While most employers are concerned about people not getting enough work done, overworking is likely a more realistic concern. There are a few main reasons why creative people end up working too much.

You're bogged down in email, Slack, and internal meetings. These activities, while they do serve a purpose, are often over-prioritized. Take a look at your calendar and see how much of the working day you're spending in meetings alone. Many people find it important to quickly respond to any email/chat that comes across their desks. Given the ubiquity of these communication tools,

it makes it really hard to actually have the time to focus on doing real work. The actual high-value thinking gets pushed to the margins of your schedule (often at night) where you can focus without the distractions.

**If this
sounds
like you...**

Make sure meetings are more efficient by asking to see an agenda before accepting any internal meeting invite.

Schedule your email time. I respond to emails three times a day. By batching my email time I don't have to keep my inbox open,

KNOW WHEN YOU'RE AT YOUR BEST:

“If I’m sketching, I know I have to do it in the morning — that’s when my brain is working. That’s when I know I can come up with new ideas. I wake up super early. After sketching, I go for a meandering walk for some inspiration. In the afternoon, I can do edits and push stuff around. In my first year I had to figure out that I had to go to bed. I realized it’d save me time...

...and energy in the long run. Before that I used to work myself ragged and stay up super late.”

-MIKEY BURTON

being constantly distracted by whatever comes in. In the vast majority of cases, people will understand if it takes you a few hours to get back to them. This is very normal. Once people adjust to your schedule it will become the new normal.

Calendar time to get your meaningful, high-value work done before you get bogged down by check-ins and other drains on your time. This can be done with a strategy called Schedule Blocking or Time Blocking. What's Schedule Blocking? Essentially, it's a way to block off the majority of your calendar on a daily/weekly basis, starting with the most important things you need to accomplish. If you make time for the most important stuff before you get bogged down in invites and check-ins, you will never let work get in the way of your goals. You are what you do every day. So, take a look at your calendar and try to figure out who you are. Chief email officer? Lead meeting manager? Make sure your calendar reflects your priorities.

You travel too much. Spending time on the road and in those pressurized metal flying tubes consumes a lot of time and even more energy. Some people can work well on airplanes while others can't. Either way, jet lag isn't helping matters. Trips require prep and packing and reservations and expense tracking. It isn't abnormal to spend the better part of two working days traveling

for a one-hour meeting.
Even worse, you show
up to work the next day
exhausted.

**If this
sounds
like you...**

See how many of your meetings you can do via video chat. I find this works especially well after you've met a client/partner in person at least once. The time and energy savings on this is enormous. An hour meeting takes an hour, not three hours with two-thirds of the time spent idling in traffic.

Figure out what work you can get done on airplanes. A lot of high-value activities are actually fairly easy to do offline. Maybe it's a good time to catch up on reading. Never rely on airplane wifi to get work done. It's far too unreliable and slow for that. Make sure you have your working materials offline.

BOSS YOUR SCHEDULE:

“When I’m traveling and teaching and doing freelance, I need to do a lot of planning to make my schedule work. I only teach Tuesdays and Thursdays, doing marathon 7–7 days. I do most of my administrative work on Friday. Monday, Wednesday, and Friday I try to focus on non-school stuff. Friday deadlines don’t work well for my schedule and because I know that I do a good job of setting expectations. Friday deadlines are stupid anyway. What’s going to happen with a project on Friday afternoon?!”

Look at the work you can do asynchronously. When you're in a different time zone it's important to look at the times you can coordinate with the rest of your office.

Schedule these check-ins as soon as you can, especially if the window where everyone is available is small. This leaves you the rest of the time to do your own work peacefully unbothered. Two personal examples: Being based in California, I find myself on the East Coast at least a few times a year. The three-hour time difference can actually be quite helpful. If I'm in New York I can usually get a solid three hours of work done before anyone shows up at the office in the Bay Area. This head start is a great advantage. I then schedule any check-ins before lunch (morning in California), which leaves me the entire afternoon for local meetings and exploring. I'll usually check in on any projects requiring follow-up before dinner, toward the end of the day in California. A full, productive day. Working from London is a lot harder. The eight-hour time difference means that there's a very small window in the late afternoon/early evening where I can communicate with the rest of the studio. Because this window is tight, I try to schedule anything where I need to coordinate with the office as early as possible — preferably before I take off. On the plus side, I'm free from morning to late afternoon to do whatever I need to do in London.

You don't delegate enough. I find a lot of creative people have a tough time delegating simple tasks to people who work for them. This can be because they are very particular about how something gets done or they simply don't trust those around them. Because you get bogged down in doing low-value activities, the high-value activities that require more attention and focus keep getting pushed to the back burner.

**If this
sounds
like you...**

Delegation is essential to your growth. Look at your daily activities and ask yourself what would be easy to train your employees to do. As they pick up these abilities and you get better at delegating, you can offload more complex tasks. More on delegation later.

If there's one advantage of the 9-to-5 workday it's that it's very clear when you should and shouldn't be working. While the specific 9-to-5 timeframe is of little utility anymore, knowing when you need to get work done and when you should be relaxing is critical. Don't jettison standard work hours just to find yourself working more than you had been before.

LISTEN TO YOUR BRAIN:

“If I don’t set aside 45 minutes to an hour to just draw in my sketchbook I feel like I’m going insane. I need to prioritize it more and then it sets the tone for the rest of the day. I took my drawing time away from my email time because I spend way...

...too much time doing email. You need to figure out what works for you and build your schedule around it. You need to listen to your brain and figure out when you work the best. I can't stay up late anymore without it ruining part of the next day. Now I work best in the mornings."

-KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

A study by Bentley University found that 89 percent of young workers regularly check their email after work hours. It feels a lot more normal to work in the evening if your office isn't on 9-to-5. This is fine if that's when you're most productive, but don't let your workday bleed into the rest of your life. Build a time structure that works for you and your employees. Value and respect the time away from work. Having the space to clear your head will pay big creative dividends and will help to ensure your employees (and you) don't burn out.

09

The yardstick

How do you
measure success?

What gets measured gets managed. In my estimation, this is the most accurate and wide-reaching statement in business. Do whatever you need to do in order to keep this top of mind.



If there's something you're trying to improve, start by measuring everything you can relate to it. You would be amazed at how many answers jump off the page. One of my favorite anecdotes about the power of simple measurement comes from Dale Carnegie's classic book *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. It's about steel magnate Charles M. Schwab. Schwab wanted to increase steel production at one of his plants, so at the end of the day, before the night shift came on, he asked one of his workers how many heats they made on their shift. The answer was six, so Schwab took a piece of chalk and wrote a big "6" on the floor. When the night shift came in they asked what the "6" was for. Someone from the day shift told them that the boss was in and asked how many heats they finished and wrote it on the floor. When the day shift showed up the following morning, the 6 had been replaced with a 7 by the night shift. The day shift, not to be outdone, worked their asses off and at the end of the shift proudly wiped off the 7 and replaced it with a big 10.

Remember: what gets measured gets managed.

We all have tons of different things to work on, check in on, edit, arrange, catalog, critique, monitor. If you're approaching these things by getting to them when you get to them, taking a hack at it, maybe having a great discussion, and then coming back to it at some time in the future, you're never going to make meaningful progress toward your goals.

“Early on I started keeping track of every inquiry that came in, organizing it into whether we got the project or not. It was half to try understanding who was reaching out, half to check back on projects to see who got them and who we were competing against. That’s grown into a more detailed list with info on what other studios were being considered for a project, what their price range is, and most importantly why did or didn’t they choose to work with us. This gives us a clear picture of how clients see us and has allowed us to communicate better on future projects.”

—BRENT COUGHMAN, MONIKER

Measurement is your way of keeping tabs on the health of your business, addressing problems before they become catastrophes, focusing on the numbers that are most important, and motivating your team.

**So, what
should
you be
measuring?**

Big picture numbers

Revenue

Expenses

Projects (how many, what type)

Lead generation / Sales

How many people go to your website?

How many people contact you?

How do they reach you?

How did they hear about you?

How many proposals do you send out?

How many people decide to hire you?

How many don't?

Why don't they?

Retention

How happy are clients with your work?
(1–5 scale is fine)

How happy are you with your clients?
(1–5 scale is fine)

When/how often will you check
in with past clients?

Which clients turn into repeat clients?

“We do monthly one-on-one lunches. Quarterly/ yearly reviews feel too far out for us. People can develop bad habits and get on the wrong path. Having a monthly lunch is a great way for us to check in and talk through decisions, issues and bottlenecks.”

A note on customer concentration: Customer concentration is the percentage of your revenue you generate from any one client. Lower customer concentration is better because it means you're running a business that doesn't rely too heavily on any given client. No client should represent more than 10 percent of your revenue. This puts you in a position where you can fire a client if you need to and not worry about it tanking your business.

Let's be clear. This involves collecting a ton of data and if you want to grow your studio, it's essential that you do it. Once you begin to collect this data, you can start to answer important questions about your business.

How many proposals do we have to send out to get a project? Which clients tend to turn into repeat clients? How many big clients would we need to hit our revenue goal? Where do our highest paying clients come from? Which projects yield the happiest clients?

A lot of people tend to answer these questions anecdotally. This is bullshit. Don't build assumptions on top of assumptions. Collect the data and know the answer. Even more importantly, once you have a baseline of data, you can see the impact of changes you make to your processes. Does this new proposal template improve our win rate? Are clients happier with our work when we present in person? There's no limit to the questions you

can ask, and the real answers you'll find once you start collecting the data.

In the beginning, your goal is to establish the baseline. You are not running experiments at this point, just trying to get an accurate, quantifiable reflection of your current efforts. Collect this info in a spreadsheet on different pages (I use Google Sheets) and gather monthly numbers for six months. This should be long enough to have a reliable baseline of information. If you already have some or all of this information in Xero, Quickbooks, Sheets, or wherever, great! You have a six-month head start.

Next you want to look for facts and patterns in the data you have collected. Start with the questions we covered earlier and add any of your own that you're curious about.

How many proposals do we have to send out to get a project? Which clients tend to turn into repeat clients? How many big clients would we need to hit our revenue goal? Where do our highest paying clients come from? Which projects yield the happiest clients?

You might not find anything groundbreaking yet. This is OK. Having and maintaining this data set will always give you something to look back on when trying to figure out what's working for your studio and what isn't. After a while you will be able to limit your focus

to numbers that are truly important to the success of your studio. The fewer numbers you focus on, the more energy you can put into your efforts to improve them. One interesting thing our Director of Client Services found at A Hundred Monkeys was that clients who asked, “What happens if I don’t like anything you come up with?” during the sales process tended to turn into projects we weren’t happy with. Now, this mechanism isn’t entirely clear but the correlation is. Maybe it has to do with clients not trusting us. Maybe it’s something else. Either way it’s a red flag and an indication to proceed with caution.

So now that you have all this data on your studio, how do you go about making these numbers move in the direction you want? For example, how do I increase quarterly revenue? You can passively collect revenue numbers every quarter for the rest of your life. What good is all this data if it doesn’t change anything about how the business actually performs? The majority of the data you have collected so far fit into a category of “lag” or “lagging” indicators. This means these numbers are great at telling you where you are or where you’ve been, but they have little to say about where you’re headed. They’re output-oriented. “Lead” or “leading” indicators represent the other side of the coin. Lead indicators are input-oriented, meaning they’re easy to influence but harder to measure.

“For us it’s a quarterly thing goals. If we’re off target we numbers up. For example, t January we had maybe 70 t lot below last year. Then we and put clear banners on B Conference is coming’ and picked up. Having year-to-y we’re supposed to be tells u Last year more people trav were expecting. The last m like crazy and we had to scr fit everyone into the afterpa and have things to measure if things don’t go according have a creative solution.”

. We set quarterly sign-up
brainstorm how to get our
this year's conference, in
tickets sold which was a
e updated our messaging
rand New saying 'The
right away ticket sales
year numbers of where
is if we're on track or not.
eled to Nashville than we
onth, ticket sales picked up
ramble to figure out how to
arty venue. It's good to plan
e yourself against, but
to plan, make sure you

-ARMIN VIT, UNDER CONSIDERATION

Let's use an example to clarify:

Say you work at a hospital (drastic career change, I know) and you're tasked with lowering the rate of Hospital-Acquired Infection. Serious business. First you could find a logical lagging indicator: How many infections are acquired at your hospital every month? This helps you see how big the problem is, but it tells you nothing about how to improve the statistic. A good leading indicator for HAI is handwashing. The more hospital workers wash or sanitize their hands, the less likely they are to spread infection. In this case, the number of infections is the lagging indicator and handwashing is a leading indicator. Armed with this information you could install more sinks or put Purell dispensers everywhere. Surprise, infections are down and you're a lifesaver.

When applied to the creative field, the relationship between most of the lagging indicators you have and any potential leading indicators can be a bit murky. This means you're going to need to make some hypotheses and run experiments to establish relationships. For every relationship you prove or disprove, you gain focus on what's important to measure and what's just noise. When you run these experiments make sure you give them enough time to pan out. For me, if I'm not seeing results in two months the relationship is either not there or it isn't potent enough to be truly valuable. With so many potential experiments

A JOB WELL DONE:

“The shadow side of our productivity culture is, how do you feel good about what you accomplish? How can you look internally and say, this is what we’ve achieved. You need to feel good about it. Creative work is really difficult to tell when it’s done. Nothing feels real unless you have clear goals.”

-JJ KAYE, HIGH PRESSURE ZONE

and hypotheses out there, don’t get bogged down looking for tiny improvements. It’s also important not to cross-contaminate by running a bunch of experiments at the same time. If you notice a change you want to be confident in what you’re attributing it to. This will require patience, so work on your deep breathing and focus on one experiment at a time per area (lead generation, sales, retention, etc.).

Here are a few example experiments you could run:

Does signing up for AdWords increase our quantity of inbound leads? Does adding a

contact form to our homepage increase inbound leads? Does redesigning our proposal template improve win rate? Does meeting a potential client in person improve win rate? Does sending chocolate to clients after projects increase the likelihood they become repeat clients? Does starting a quarterly newsletter increase site traffic?

For every metric and experiment you establish, set up a logical interval for measurement. Remember, focus on the metrics that you truly want to improve. Some things you only need to look at yearly while others require weekly attention. At A Hundred Monkeys we review inbound leads weekly. We review metrics like win rate, site visits, contact form submissions, and retention efforts monthly. We review all financials and any new experiments quarterly. Figure out check-in intervals and methods (Does this need to be a meeting? How about a simple update?) that work for your studio and adjust as necessary. By quickly looking at your numbers you should easily be able to tell if you're on target or not. Don't overcomplicate things. Make it easy to update and easy to understand. If it isn't getting used on a regular basis, it isn't easy enough.

Lastly, it's important to measure the performance and progress of everyone in the studio. This is typically done every six months or every year. At A Hundred Monkeys it's done every six months. If you think sitting

down and reviewing how employees are doing every six months is too corporate or overkill, you are very wrong. People need to know how they are doing. They need to know if they're doing what's expected of them and if they're meeting their goals. In his Harvard Business Review article "The Easiest Thing You Can Do to Be a Great Boss," author David Sturt shows that companies with strong recognition practices have higher levels of employee satisfaction. A 2015 study found that 70 percent of employees who report receiving some form of recognition from their boss say they're happy with their jobs. More frequent recognition also increases job satisfaction. Having a venue for recognition, improvement, and goal setting is essential to keeping your studio happy and motivated.

We use a simple review framework that you can find here (runstudiorun.com/resources). It is important to commit your reviews to paper so when you have your next review with an employee you both have a reference. Where were improvements made? Were specific goals met? From a Human Resources perspective, it is also important to hold onto copies of employee reviews. This makes it easy to track the progress, strengths, and areas for improvement for everyone in the studio. I bring the current review sheet and last half's review sheet to every employee review. This way you can easily reference what you discussed last time and gauge progress.

Don't weigh employees down with large lists of improvements. Keep your focus limited so they feel the value of what you're focusing on. People get confused and overwhelmed when you give them a laundry list of things they can improve on. Take the time and ask yourself "If this person could make one critical improvement to how they work, what would it be?" This way you can spend some of your time together working through ways to specifically improve. They will leave the review with a clear picture of what's expected of them.

Be a good listener in reviews. There's a lot you can learn by sitting back and listening to what your employees are looking for, where they see their career progressing and what they would like to improve on. Ask good questions. What are some good review questions? Try these:

What is the hardest part of your job?

What is the most important thing you've learned at work this year?

When you get really busy, what part of your work suffers first?

What project was most enjoyable for you this year?

If you could grow your skills in one key area, what would it be?

If you can understand what motivates the people who work for you, you're in a much better position to lead and grow your studio.

So start measuring your most important metrics. Every year or so, check back in to make sure that your most important metrics are still critical. Resist the temptation to jump around, valuing whichever numbers seem to be working in your favor. Put in the time initially to make a calculated guess, and then use the 12 months ahead of you to track, understand, and assess the value of the data you're collecting. Doing this at A Hundred Monkeys we realized while tracking the overall leads we receive that tracking the leads we receive from past clients and their direct referrals was a much more valuable metric for us. These projects led to more work we were proud of and better relationships. By committing to this metric we now have a much larger referral network that continues to build on itself. Remember that tracking isn't a passive process. If you pay close attention you'll be drawn toward what really matters for your studio.

10

Staying busy

Clients and where
they're hiding

Where do your clients come from? Instead of coming up with an answer to this deceptively simple question, most creative firms plow forward attempting to do 10 things at once, talking to whoever will listen, and hoping something sticks.



This is what leads to sad blogs that haven't been updated in eight months. Just like with branding or design, trying to attract everyone at the same time almost never works. While creative professionals spend a lot of time helping their clients understand and communicate with their audience, it appears that a lot of small agencies spend very little time doing this for themselves. If it's good enough for your clients it should be good enough for you.

The funnel represents the life cycle of your business-generating apparatus. Wait, what's a funnel? Good question. A funnel is a visual metaphor for the process through which potential leads become clients.

These potential leads start at the top of the funnel and progress toward the bottom. If you converted 100 percent of the projects that came your way, your funnel would look more like a tube but even the best lose sometimes.

DEVELOPMENT:

“The goal of business development is to bring stability to your business. Without BD, most smaller creative shops are feast or famine. When you’re doing great, who needs BD? But when you’re in a lull, you can’t react fast enough to bring yourself out of it. It’s called Business Development. It takes time. Most smaller creative firms are not proactive when it comes to finding work. They’re 100 percent reactive. This becomes a big issue when the leads dry up.”

Here's an example funnel:

*Chance of turning into a client

Qualification

1%*

The first step for any opportunity. Anyone who sends you an email or calls you or shows any interest at all in working with you goes into this category.

Qualified

25%*

There is a real project that you're going after.

Proposal

33%*

You discuss the opportunity with the client to the point of putting a proposal on the table.

Shortlisted

50%*

The client liked your proposal and has follow-up questions, points to negotiate on.

Contracts

98%*

You're into the nitty gritty of getting signatures.

Signed

100%*

You're off to the races.

WHO ARE THESE SUITS?:

“A lot of creative firms are allergic to BD (business development). They think it will ruin their culture. They think it’s a big investment in something (or someone) that doesn’t appreciate the creative craft.”

-TIM FISHER, SCANSION

Note: If you don’t get the project or decide not to pursue at any stage, the client exits the funnel and stays in your CRM for occasional check-ins if you believe there might be a new opportunity in the future. If you don’t have a CRM, I strongly recommend getting one. It’s basically a fancy online address book where you can easily keep track of everyone who you come in contact with. That way when you have big news to share or need to find a new project manager, you don’t have to send out a bunch of emails ad hoc every time. Most CRMs can actually manage and visualize your funnel for you, too.

Not all funnels look the same, however. Look at your process and figure out a funnel that works for you. It will likely change over time. As you put more and more potential projects through the funnel, you can revise your percentages. All of this is in the name of being able to predict your deal flow (or how much business you have on the horizon). If you collect enough data to confidently say that 40 percent of projects that get to a proposal turn into clients, you can update your projections, and more importantly, know how much money you're expecting to receive in a few months.

These projections become important when you're asking yourself questions like:

“How busy will we be in August?”

“Should we be putting more effort into outbound business development?”

“Are we going to hit our revenue goals for the quarter?”

“Do we need to hire someone?”

“Will we have enough money to make payroll?”

Keep your business development practice and funnel up to date by scheduling a little time every week for your BD efforts. The more you use and adapt your process to your studio, the more you'll get out of it.

**“If you
chase two
rabbits,
you will
not catch
either one.”**

—RUSSIAN PROVERB

Lead Generation

Lead generation is the process by which you attract new clients. This can be done both in person and online. Online lead generation involves attracting new potential clients through ads (Google AdWords, Twitter ads, Facebook ads, industry-specific ads, guest blogging, search engine optimization, retargeting, and myriad other activities), all aimed at getting interested potential clients to contact you. The conversion rate on these activities is typically very low.

The more specific and targeted you can be, the better. For example, if you're trying to have your ads show up when people Google "graphic designer," you're going to be spending a lot of money because this is a popular search term for people looking for designers (262,000,000,000 — yes, billion — Google results as of first publication). Instead, the term "mountain biking graphic design" (1,730,000 results) will be much less competitive and will result in much more specific leads. Knowing your focus from Chapter 2 is important here. Who specifically would you like to communicate with? Know your audience and test a bunch of ways to get in contact with them. There are plenty of SEO/SEM firms who can help you with all of this. If you have more time than money, it might be something you'd prefer to do yourself. If you want to go it alone, there are a lot of resources online and in print that can help you out.

SET YOUR SIGHTS:

"Your funnel starts with focus. You need to understand what types of projects and clients you're after. Look at your past projects and figure out which projects were the most profitable, most marketable, and most fun."

-TIM FISHER, SCANSION

Focus and hone a single way to reach out to potential leads. Warm leads — people you already know or have a real connection to (as opposed to a LinkedIn connection) — will always do better than cold leads (people you don't know but would like to know). You need to provide some value and insight for them initially to grab their attention. This is not a short-term game, either. You're planting seeds here and they might take a while to sprout.

At least initially, don't focus on how many people you contact. Focus on what you're delivering, how you're delivering it, and what the response rate is. Track the people who get back to you in a CRM so you can reach out infrequently. Depending on how interested they are you can find opportunities to get coffee or, if they're a little less interested, send them something small and cool in the mail from time to time. We're big fans of sending screen-printed posters and chocolate. Who doesn't like receiving nice chocolate in the mail? No one I want to work with. Try out a few things and see what gets people to pick up the conversation.

While knowing your audience is important, testing is crucial. You need to track Return on Investment for all of your lead generation activities. Look at your online lead generation activities as a series of closely monitored experiments. If experiments aren't generating leads and clients in a couple of months, modify the experiment or move onto the next one.

BE INDUSTRIOUS:

“You’re in the creative industry but your clients are in their own industries. They have their own sets of rules, players, events. Pick an industry. Subscribe to a newsletter. Get fucking smart with that industry.”

-JJ KAYE, HIGH PRESSURE ZONE

Once you find an experiment that is working, increase your spend (be it time or money or both) until you find the saturation point — where more cash in doesn’t necessarily mean more cash out.

Generating leads in person tends to have a much higher conversion rate. It also happens to take more time. This is primarily done through attending events, meet-ups, and conferences. A lot of creative professionals I know spend time going to creative conferences and events. There’s nothing wrong with this — I’ve attended and spoken at some great creative events over the years. But if your goal is lead generation, you’re going to want to attend events where your client audience is going to be. It might not sound like fun but going to a healthcare conference might be a much better way to find good work than hanging out with the AIGA.

Clients

Your current clients represent your most captive audience. They're already communicating with you on a regular basis. They probably even respect you. Every time you communicate with them or share work, you're either solidifying or deteriorating the relationship. Asking a lot of questions and carefully listening (actually listening, not doing a good job of looking like you're listening) to the answers should yield a lot of opportunities for more work. Take good notes because the opportunities might not be immediate. If you're designing packaging for a new product and the client casually mentions another product line launching next year, write it down. Sales people call this "Land and Expand." Land the client. Expand the opportunity. Checking back with them at the right time is a great indicator that you care about the relationship and you're on top of your shit. It's easy, just use calendar or Slack reminders (more on Slack later).

Alumni

Alumni are past clients. Just like you're an alumni of Cal State Dominguez Hills, your past clients are alumni of your studio. For business development purposes, focus on who you liked working with because it's highly likely you would enjoy working with them again. Your alumni should be your single greatest source of leads because not only can they decide to work with

you again, they can refer you to friends and colleagues. These friends and colleagues are basically business development gold — they already believe in you because someone they trust (your alumni) trusts you. They are also likely to make good clients because they get along with a client you already like. Jackpot. If for whatever reason your alumni aren't a strong source of leads, you need to solidify your process and offering until you have happy clients who are willing to recommend you to everyone they know. Don't be shy here either. If you're unsure a client you enjoyed working with would refer you to their friends, ask.

GET OUT THERE:

“We started with a Kickstarter to get a project out there — to get some visibility. We rounded up 10 different local designers and did a project called ‘Oakland Illustrated.’ That certainly helped with getting the business up and running in the beginning. We wanted to do more collaboration and work with more artists and designers. We really don’t do any advertising. By using word of mouth and social media we organically evolved and picked up some like-minded clients.”

—JENNY PAN, THE WEEKEND PRESS

Sales/Conversion

This is where you qualify the potential projects from your lead generation efforts. Use a CRM (or a spreadsheet) to keep track of everyone you contact, when you contact them, and what your next point of contact will be. We use HubSpot. Pay close attention to which leads turn into projects and why. Here are some potential questions you can ask yourself:

Do we have more success with higher or lower cost projects?

How many conversations are needed to get to a signed agreement/SOW?

Are you speaking with the actual decision maker?

Is the project a rush?

Are multiple agencies bidding on the project?

Did you enjoy the conversation with the potential client?

After one call/video conference, how confident are you in winning the project?

Do you think this will be an enjoyable project?

Keeping track of this data is important because you can test your gut feelings and assumptions against the facts. A lot of people at creative agencies tend to do this by “feel,” saying things like “We typically do well pitching apparel projects.” Oh yeah? Because you’ve worked on two of them? Having the data will give you the ability to test whatever hypothesis you have and rapidly improve your conversion rate and overall sales process. Once projects are complete, revisit the data you have and see if your assumptions were correct. Were they in fact a good client? Did having direct contact with the decision maker lead to a better outcome?

“I started because I wanted to figure out my personal style — what I was passionate about. I was working in other places before that. I worked a year alone from my home, working with friends and friends of friends. One year later I brought on Ricardo, an illustrator, and started building a portfolio. We started with smaller projects. Once we had enough to show, we sent this portfolio all around Barcelona, digitally and physically. We did a lot of calls. I spent a lot of energy actively working to find clients and it worked for us. One portfolio I sent was to *Monocle* magazine. They responded four months later wanting to do a commission. It was a year without money — just small clients. I was investing in building a portfolio. I needed something to show. Now I get a lot of PDFs and emails from people who are starting out. I can’t respond to them all. It helps to send something nice and physical. It stands out.”

Inbound vs. Outbound

What's the difference between inbound and outbound leads? Simple. Inbound leads make the first move and come to you. Outbound leads you go and get, putting in the work (or the calls or the emails) to find projects. Either way you need a system for qualifying your leads. How much is the project worth? Is there potential for future work? Will you be able to market the project after it's done and attract clients you want to work with? Will the project be profitable? Have a scorecard to inform your decisions. It won't be making decisions for you, but it's a good way to inform your decision-making process.

Eventually, if you want to grow, you likely need to build a focused strategy for outbound business development. Focus on an industry or specific project type (this should build on the big focus of your studio). Don't spread yourself too thin trying to go after too many opportunities at the same time. Once you get to a certain size, you need to be more proactive about growing your business. If you're going to grow (and hire) you need to make sure there's enough work to keep your studio busy. This is a natural fit for outbound business development.

As you really start to make a name for yourself, there should be more demand than supply. You can hire to meet demand (assuming you have solid creative and hiring processes) or you can

raise your rates and become more selective. This is essentially back to an inbound model where the majority of your work comes to you.

When it comes to inbound versus outbound marketing there seems to be a large preference amongst creative professionals for inbound leads. This makes sense. Inbound leads come to you. It's nice when your new business process is answering friends' calls when they have projects for you. If this is enough to sustain your business, more power to you. Each new project is an opportunity to slowly expand your network and grow the base of people who can call you up and say, "Hey, I got something for you." Additionally, a lot of creatives lean more introverted. Inbound marketing is a lot

“The entire process by which the business does business is a marketing tool, a mechanism for finding and keeping customers.”

easier for introverts because you're generally only speaking with people you know or are one degree away from.

Conversely, outbound marketing presents opportunities to get in front of large audiences. You can speak at conferences, guest blog, go to industry events, make newsletters, the list is never ending. It's a numbers game. Outbound marketing is about putting yourself out there and seeing who's interested. There's generally more room for creativity in outbound marketing — you can always find new ways to make a name for yourself. Some people really enjoy doing this sort of work. They like putting themselves out there. They crave recognition. If this sounds like you, build an outbound marketing plan with clear goals, milestones, and metrics.

Curate your portfolio to support your growth and reinforce your focus. This means only show work you're proud of, and would like more of, on your site. Ask yourself "If I had a potential client say, 'I love the work you did for [insert potential portfolio project] and was looking for something similar,'" would you be excited about this prospect? Remember, just because you do a project, doesn't mean you need to tell the world about it. You should constantly be showing and talking about the type of work that you truly want. If your homepage is full of apps you've worked on, who's going to be knocking on your door with new projects? That's right, software engineers who just moved to San Francisco.

“THE
YEAR
NO

ELL
HOR
D.”

—DEREK SIVERS

BUILD ON YOUR WORK:

“We look to build longer lasting relationships where we can work and grow with clients over time. It’s important that our clients like us and our process. You push each other, and as you build trust you make better work over time. Working with new clients that come to us out of the blue is fine and it’s good to start new relationships, but when you need to begin a new relationship from scratch every few months, it takes more energy and time to find out how you work together. Ultimately we believe it’s valuable to build a network up where our clients know each other and you can reinforce your relationships and build trust in your network.”

-TOM CRABTREE, MANUAL

Overall, the goal of a funnel is to track and measure your efforts. You can start with a simple spreadsheet and as you begin to track more and more you can import your spreadsheet into a more robust CRM like HubSpot or Pipedrive or even Salesforce (which is probably overkill for a 20-person studio). Every lead goes through a funnel. It’s a volume game. Keep your leads moving through the funnel. Politely remove yourself from the process if you reach the point where you’re confident it’s not a good project for

you. Remember, no one is looking out for you here. The company you're talking to will be fine if you say no. Do not feel bad about extricating yourself if and when you have to. It's a bit like online dating — keep moving forward until you're in a relationship or you're confident this isn't the one for you. I'd say something about swiping right here but my hope is that this book outlives that terminology.

If you are looking to improve the conversion rate of your funnel, start from the bottom and work your way up. Why pour more time and money into the top of your funnel if most of your leads are leaking out anyway? Focusing on the bottom means you're spending more time figuring out how to convert the leads you're already getting. Once you get up to a good win percentage, your lead generation efforts at the top of the funnel will be magnified.

The two most important things about finding work are putting consistent effort into a method that works for you and tracking those efforts. If you find a productive method, be it inbound, outbound, online or off, dive into it. Figure out how and why it works. Keep experimenting and evolving based on what you learn. Tracking your efforts keeps you accountable. You aren't guessing at how effective your approach is, you know. And if the results start fading, go right back to experimentation and find something that works better.

11

Is this project worth your time?

It better be

There's a lot of debate about which projects are worth doing and why.

Do you take the corporate projects that pay well and are usually pretty boring and bureaucratic?

Or do you take the cool independent projects that never have any budget?



“We definitely say no to more projects than we say yes to. There are three major things we need to see. We have to be interested in what the company is doing. We need to be passionate and intrigued about it. Financially it needs to support the team that we’re going to have on the project. The third thing is the people. Who are these people? What’s their track record? Are they suited for the task at hand? We interview them as much as they’re interviewing us. We’re looking for people who are doing something new, something that hasn’t been done before.”

When you're asking yourself if a project is worth your time, it's a question of cost and time but also about your interest level and what the project means to you and your portfolio.

**This
seems like
a good
place for
a pros and
cons list —**

Corporate Work

Usually pays well

Has the potential for high visibility

More opportunities for
repeat business

Looks good on the client list

Pros

Independent Work

More creative freedom
and control

Grateful clients

Create work you want to show off

Easy to schedule and bill

Corporate Work

Usually a lot of decision makers

Multiple levels of bureaucracy

Work might never see the
light of day

Generally risk-averse

Cons

Independent Work

Sometimes don't have their
shit together

Little to no money

Now, sometimes you will find a corporate project with a client who's willing to take risks or limits the number of decision makers. You might even find a cool, independent project that has a good budget. These clients are gold. Treat them as such. Inversely, you might find a big corporate client with no budget or a small job with a lot of bureaucracy. Proceed with extreme caution and/or hit the eject button.

YOU'RE WORTH IT:

“It takes so much time to figure out what something's worth. I like asking clients what they really think a project is worth. Don't sell yourself short. If it doesn't go through, something else will come along. But if it does work, you're getting the price you want so you aren't going into it with a bad attitude.”

Going back to measurement, it's important to be able to evaluate what a project is worth to you. What can you measure to ensure you're picking good projects? Keep track of all the projects you take, how you feel about their potential when you start and how they end up. A simple 1–5 scale rating the work output and your satisfaction with the project is enough. Start to get a sense for what factors are important in establishing if a project will be successful and profitable.

Some agencies are very vigilant about time tracking and hours. Once you scale to a bigger business this becomes important. When you're small, it's more important to understand some simple parameters around what makes a project profitable and what makes it a black hole of time and money.

Every time we make significant updates to our process at A Hundred Monkeys, I find it's good to track hours on two or three "standard" projects. Have employees track their hours in a spreadsheet and do the math to figure out how much the project is costing you. You can use these sample projects as guideposts for other projects so you have a sense for what a profitable project feels like. Some people like to use time management software or apps here. Personally, I think if you aren't tracking hours on everything, these aren't worth the time and money. The reason we don't track hours on all projects is simple: because time tracking

TIME WELL SPENT:

“In the beginning, we weren’t tracking hours. Now we’re doing it to get a sense for how long a certain type of project takes us. We don’t bill by the hour, we still quote on a per-project basis. But you still need to know how long a project will take. We account for meetings, writing emails, travel. We’re not 100 percent accurate, but we have a good idea of how long certain types of projects take.”

—ED NG, TUNG

takes time. If your margins are good enough on average, knowing the small differences between projects won’t do you much good. Once you start to reach eight or more people it gets tougher to have a sense for what everyone in

the studio is working on and how long they're taking. If this becomes an ongoing concern, begin to trial time tracking programs with a few projects or a few employees and expand it to everyone if you find it valuable.

Here's a sample spreadsheet we have used to track time (runstudiorun.com/resources). Through doing this exercise, we found out that travel, in both cars and planes, was a major drain on our resources. Sure, the meeting might just be an hour but that doesn't include the two hours wasted in traffic getting to and from the meeting. Thanks, Silicon Valley. What if you just traveled to the project kickoff or a big presentation and agreed to do the rest of the meetings over video conference? How much time would you save?

Time management is another reason why having a limited offering is important — you get a good sense for how long projects take and what they cost you to execute. Through doing this, you will establish a floor. Your floor is the minimum you can charge for a project and not lose money. This means you're covering your studio's time and project-related expenses. Your floor should only be available for projects that you are extremely excited about — work that will help grow your portfolio and attract other clients you would be excited to work with. With any luck, some of these new clients will have bigger budgets.

In 2011, a London cupcake shop decided to offer a Groupon discount for 75 percent off. Sounds harmless enough, right? Well, this little bakery ended up having to make 102,000 cupcakes. Because the owner had to hire to meet the demand, the shop ended up losing almost £16,000 (around \$20,000 at the time) on the orders. This is why you need to know where your floor is.

One of the biggest mistakes smaller creative studios make is not charging enough. If you're an expert at your niche and you have a great portfolio, you should be charging a premium price. Yes, you will be too expensive for some clients. That's OK. The ones that do hire you will know what you cost and value your work. When they refer you to friends and colleagues, they will know what you cost, too. If you take work at a discount, you will likely be taking any referrals that stem from the project at a discount, too. You're being too generous.

If a project isn't profitable for you, politely say no. Saying no is very difficult for some people. For these people it tends to be a much bigger issue than just turning down potential projects. Not being able to say no can easily work its way into all aspects of your life, ensuring you waste tons of your time doing things you aren't excited about because you're afraid of letting people (who you might not even know!) down. When you have done the work to track the hours and

know a potential project will lose you money, it's a lot easier to say those magical two letters because you know exactly what you're saying no to. It's totally fine to tell them why you're saying no, too. "Sorry, if we did the project at this price we would be losing money" is pretty hard to argue with. It also happens to be a really good way to negotiate in these situations.

On a related note, do not do spec work. Ever. If you haven't heard of spec work, it's basically when someone (usually via email) asks you to do work for them for free, except instead of free, they say it's for "exposure." You see, they have a vast, diverse audience and thousands if not millions of people will see your work. Lies. If they had that big of an audience they should be able to find some money to pay you. If you need a good template for saying no to spec work, look no further than designer Dan Cassaro's email exchange with Showtime. Spec work is bad for you. It's bad for your profession. It makes no economic sense. If you find yourself wanting to trade work for exposure, do work that you're personally passionate about and share it with your audience, even if it's a small one. You can build your audience this way and attract like-minded people.

It is also important to consider if a potential project is in line with your beliefs. Morals don't mean anything until they cost you something. You can say that you would never work for

[insert company you despise], but until they show up at your door being way friendlier and more reasonable than you thought they'd be, waving cash around, that moral stance you're taking means nothing. We all want to run profitable businesses, but there's some money that just isn't worth taking.

Think carefully about the lines you won't cross and when companies on the other sides of those lines come knocking, and they will, be polite and firm. The lines you establish don't have to be company-based (although they certainly can be). For example, say you despise Walmart but they come to you looking for help promoting a transition to exclusively non-aerosol products. You could see this simply as "I don't like Walmart so I won't work for them." Fair enough. You could also say "While I don't like Walmart, they're clearly trying to do something good here and because of their size and purchasing power this project will have a large positive impact. I'm willing to put my greater disdain aside." The point is, it's up to you to establish these lines. Some projects are worth saying no to and some companies are worth saying no to as well.

Some people might say that if you turn down a project, there will always be someone who's willing to say yes. That's probably right. To this I say that you can only be responsible for your impact and your studio's impact. You're the one who needs to feel good about the work you're doing. No one else can do that for you.

WHERE DO THE HOURS GO?:

“I couldn’t live without time tracking. It helps me estimate. It checks assumptions. Say we had 30 hours estimated for this and spend 80... What happened?”

–JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

Projects consume so much time and energy. In the end you should be proud of what you make and if you’re working on a project that doesn’t align with your beliefs, how can you be proud of it? You certainly wouldn’t promote it, so aside from the cash, there’s little, if nothing, to gain.

12

So big right now

What does growth
mean to you?

In practical terms,
growth just means
managing what you
measure. If you know
what measurements
are important to
the success of your
business, growth is
figuring out a plan for
getting there.



It's really important to point out at this juncture that growth doesn't necessarily mean turning your studio into a bigger one. Growth doesn't have to be about how many people work for you or how much money you make. For a lot of people it is but it definitely doesn't have to be. Some studios are small because they want to be. Others are small because they haven't figured out a way to get big yet. Growth could just as easily be about the type of work you want to be doing or the client base you want to engage with. Growth means progress toward the business that you want to have.

GET YOUR PRIORITIES STRAIGHT:

“We don’t want to get big and lose touch. Bobby and I want to stay involved with the work. Our roles have evolved over time, but quality always comes first. The goal is to do great stuff, challenge the team and someday give ourselves a break.”

—JENNIFER KINON, OCD

If you draw out the structure of most businesses, you end up with a pyramid. There are a few leaders at the top and various layers of staff building the foundation. Bigger organizations naturally have more layers in their pyramids. Big decisions get made at the top while more discreet areas of the business, like forecasting and auditing, get managed by people who report up the chain of command. Most creative agencies, especially the smaller ones, tend to have shallow pyramids. This means that there are very few levels, if any, between the entry-level hire and the studio leadership. How shallow is your pyramid?

While shallow pyramids can be efficient businesses, they are also prone to decision bottlenecks. If there are only one or two people in your organization who can approve work or present to clients or have new business conversations, you are limiting your growth and likely missing chances to develop the skill sets of more junior members of your team.

Different structures work well for different studios. Some work better with a partner model where each partner is responsible for managing their own team and finding their own work. If you have multiple senior people who are capable of signing new work and managing a team, this model could work well for you. Other studios prefer a more traditional structure where everyone reports up the food chain. When you're small, you are more likely to start

with this traditional approach until you reach a size where you can decide to add a partner (either in your same location or by opening a new location) or continue to grow your existing structure. As you can imagine, growth can be rather unwieldy without process. While different partners will certainly have different styles and personalities, without process it can be hard to tie everything together. What does it mean for a client to work with your studio when the work coming from different partners is vastly different? Your process, that's what.

LOOK AT THE BIG PICTURE:

“We didn’t want to get bored. Type design has an awful lot of drudgery in it. Running a studio in general does too. To keep an eye on the big picture we have an annual meeting when we get together in one room. These meetings are where we come up with big ideas like going on a tour. That’s where we float some of the stranger ideas and check in with everyone to see where things are inefficient and where we can do better.”

—CHRISTIAN SCHWARTZ, COMMERCIAL TYPE

I'M FINE RIGHT HERE:

“People come to me every day and say ‘We like what you do and we want to make you bigger.’ They want something. They want a cut. I don’t need any more.”

-AARON DRAPLIN, DRAPLIN DESIGN CO.

Put people in charge of their growth. In smaller agencies, it'd be nice if you could give everyone healthy raises on a regular basis. Obviously, you need to grow the studio to make this possible without taking a pay cut yourself. And who's going to grow the business? You? Well, if it's you, you might not feel so great about sharing the fruits of your hard work. You might give bonuses or small raises, but this reinforces the idea that you're the one going out, finding and winning new business, bringing it back to the office for everyone to reap the rewards. People will feel like they work for you (and they aren't wrong).

UNFAMILIAR FACES:

“We’re at nine people. That’s about as big as we think we can get while still having fun. I have friends who run 30- or 50-person studios and they walk into the office and someone says hi and they say, I don’t actually know who that person is.”

—PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

The more you can share the responsibility of growth, the more you can put people in a position to create their own success and contribute to the growth of the studio in a meaningful way. Put people in charge of parts of the funnel. Give people ways to grow into leaders and contributors. By giving them responsibility and accountability, you’re taking some heavy lifting off your shoulders and passing those bricks onto someone hungry for an opportunity to prove themselves. If they truly feel like they own it, they will devote more time and energy to succeeding in their

charge than you would ever be able to. They will gain expertise and marketable skills. If they succeed, the company will grow and they will earn every penny of a raise or bonus. If they fail, not receiving a raise will come as no surprise. After an honest discussion, they should be motivated to improve. Do everything you can to align your incentives with your employees' incentives. Sharing the responsibility and benefits of growth is a winning proposition for everyone involved.

KNOW YOUR ROLE:

“It’s easy to keep growing but before you know it, you’ve created a monster. I like working with creative people and being a part of a team, but I don’t particularly like managing people.”

-TOM CRABTREE, MANUAL

Work with your employees to develop quarterly projects for them to have a specific responsibility in growing the studio. This is an idea I got from Justin Kerr's *How to Write an Email* (ExtraCurricular Press, 2015). When you're busy, it's hard to set aside time to improve and grow the business. Everyone at A Hundred Monkeys has a quarterly project with the goal of improving the business in some tangible way. Employees are in charge of New Business, Marketing, and Retention. At the beginning of the quarter you present your goal for the end of the quarter and your plan for how you will achieve it. There are monthly check-ins. Brief weekly updates can be helpful, too. These projects can compound on one another, which gives people the opportunity to build their skill sets. For example, if someone in your studio is charged with managing client retention, their first quarterly project could be inputting all of your past client contact information into a CRM. The following quarterly project could be about researching and implementing a check-in schedule for past clients.

If improving the business is a priority for your studio, this needs to be reflected on everyone's calendar. As I said earlier, your calendar needs to reflect your priorities. It is also important that the outcomes of these projects are measurable. If the outcome is "We learned some important stuff about client retention that we will bake into our future efforts," that is practically useless to you and everyone you work with. If outcomes from the beginning of a quarter are measurable there will be no debate as to whether a goal is met or not. Everyone needs to be clear about what he or she is aiming for and what success looks like. If someone in the studio can string a series of quarterly projects together, they become the de facto subject matter expert in the office. This is positive for a few reasons: it gives them a sense of responsibility and accomplishment; it builds their overall skillset, which makes them more valuable to your studio and wherever their career might take them; and it allows everyone in the studio to be able to grow the studio in a meaningful way. Now you can feel good about giving out bonuses and raises.

PACK A PUNCH:

“We’re asking ourselves what the next phase is. We don’t want to be stagnant but we’re definitely not after massive growth either. After nine years we’ve got to this point where working with a small local restaurant doesn’t challenge us anymore. We’re trying to stay small but punch above our weight as a studio. I like the challenge of that.”

Another thing: don't put your name on the building. At a certain point it's hard to scale if clients see the business as You with a bunch of helpers. Your time is a finite resource and it should become more rarified as you grow. If you're empowering your team to meaningfully contribute to the growth and success of the studio, don't take all the credit by having the company be named after you. This will make it harder to grow because you're fostering the perception that you're the person everyone wants to work with. Clients who hire you and don't work with you personally will feel like they're less important. Do yourself a favor and make it clear to everyone that your studio is bigger than you. This will help you grow, and even potentially help you sell the business in the long run.

How
big
too

So big right now

Unless you're running a publicly traded company (if you are: wrong book) you have no responsibility to grow your company. No one is forcing you to get bigger. The board will not be searching for your replacement. Only you can set the limits for your growth — and you should.

Is
big?

GIVE ME ONE REASON:

**“I don’t need to get bigger.
If I made more cash,
I wouldn’t have any time
to spend it.”**

—AARON DRAPLIN, DRAPLIN DESIGN CO.

This likely has nothing to do with growing your studio to a certain number of employees. Size is a horrible metric for success, especially in the creative field. Growth goes back to goal-setting. Why are you working in the first place? What are you trying to accomplish? These questions seem deceptively trite but without them you will never feel any real sense of accomplishment. Here are a few potential answers:

I want to keep doing the work I truly enjoy: As your studio grows, the variety of work you personally do will shrink. This is natural as you bring on people to specialize in certain roles. If you’re a designer, maybe it’s important that you only grow to a size where you can keep designing every day. How much time do you think the heads of massive design organizations spend actually designing? With a few exceptions, probably not much.

I want to make enough money to move to a

good school district: Maybe for you, running your studio is a means to an end. You don't necessarily need to build a large studio to accomplish this goal. You could prioritize building a lean, efficient studio with low overhead where you can retain much of your revenue. You could also prioritize keeping limited hours so you can spend more time with your family. You will still benefit from building a team and spending your time on higher value activities but the line from growth to revenue must be a clear one.

I want to produce incredible, thought-provoking work: If you wish to do this at scale (without working on a single project at a time), building a structure that frees you up to spend large chunks of time thinking and creating is essential. You should be allergic to activities like invoicing and emailing. You need a team that can do the heavy lifting so you can spend your time doing mental gymnastics. Once you build this structure and process you will be in a good position to find another partner with similar aspirations should you so choose.

Remember that growth is a function of your goals. Try not to build a big studio just to have a big studio. There is little light at the end of that tunnel. Actually, to extend the metaphor, the tunnel just keeps on getting longer. Growth should serve a purpose. This will allow you to stay passionate and engaged in your work — because you're clear on why you're doing it.

13

Delicate delegates

How to share
responsibilities
like a boss

Delegation isn't
telling people who
work for you to do
things you don't
want to do yourself.
Delegation is a
training process.



This training process is about teaching junior team members new skills that grow their expertise, and crucially, free up senior team members for more high-value activities that put their skillsets to the test.

Start by having your senior team members track their hours for a week. Track your own hours as well. You should have already done this in the earlier chapter titled “Is this project worth your time?” Make it clear that this tracking will not factor into compensation or promotion in any way. You want honest answers, not flawless schedules. Once you and your senior staff have a week’s worth of data, get together and look at what you find. The key question to ask here is: How many hours of training would it take for a junior employee to competently do this for me with one or two check-ins? Scheduling, invoicing, booking travel, meeting prep. Have your senior team (it’s fine if it’s just you) order their weekly activities from lowest number of training hours to highest, giving priority to recurring activities. Next, discuss who would be best suited for training on the activities you wish to delegate. Then build a simple plan for implementation: Which tasks are highest priorities? What’s the best way to train someone how to do this in a way where you’d be happy with the result? What are the most logical places for checking in?

Delegation doesn’t always go smoothly. More than anything, it’s a test of your communication

SET YOU FREE:

“I’m not a perfectionist. I’d rather just have stuff be done in a timely fashion. If I had someone else write a nice email, someone who’s capable of being firm when they need to be, that’s fine. That frees me up in a lot of ways.”

ability. It's hard to accurately tell someone to do something that is second nature to you. See the work that comes back and figure out how you can explain what you're looking for more clearly. If I ask someone to work on something and what they get back to me isn't what I'm looking for, I always point the finger at myself first. Explaining things in a way that yields the result you're looking for requires having a very clear idea of what you're looking for and being able to lay out that vision for someone else. It takes time and even more patience.

This is not about delegating coffee runs and photocopies. It's fine if you have interns or new employees take on these responsibilities, but don't pat yourself on the shoulder for delegating something a competent sixth grader could do. Again, think about delegation as a way to build the skills of your junior employees while freeing your senior team for some heavy lifting.

SHARING IS CARING:

“We both like to teach people — to share the craft and the history. Christian and I really enjoy that. We like to think of ourselves as good citizens of graphic design and type design. We're proud of the designers who have worked for us and went on to do wonderful things.”

—PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

PRIDE OF OWNERSHIP:

“In our structure, each designer is responsible for the coordination of their own projects. The creative work is a team effort but I find that more successful work actually gets made when the designer has ownership of the management and presentation of a project.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

You should work toward developing a mental alarm where you recognize when you're about to do work that someone else could or should be doing instead. At small studios responsibilities tend to bleed into each other and leaders are often quick to jump into the fray. Try to step back and be more critical of your workload. Spending the time and energy upfront to train someone else pays big dividends in the long run.

14

Joining forces

How and when to hire

The single biggest expense for most creative studios (and most professional services companies in general) is salary. So, hiring an office manager for the sake of appearances is never a good idea.



When you're just starting out and only have a few people that comprise your studio, it's OK to embrace the all hands on deck mentality. Even if you have someone who is responsible for picking up the phone or making sure your deliveries go out, what happens when they go to the bathroom? God forbid they ever go on vacation. When you're small, say three people or fewer, everyone is going to need to pitch in. This is good because it means that your leadership is intimately involved with the inner workings of the studio.

HIRE, OR DON'T:

“I don’t want it to be bigger or better or smarter because then I’m going to have an account manager sitting in front of me looking for something to do. I’ve stayed small. Sometimes I’ll just do a job because it’s fun.”

—AARON DRAPLIN, DRAPLIN DESIGN CO.

At some point, though, you will find yourself with more to do than you have time for. The phone will go unanswered and you'll forget to reorder toilet paper and need to steal some from the people down the hall. This puts you in a position where you can either turn down work to continue making Costco runs or hire someone new to free up your valuable time. When this happens, there are a some things you can do:

Continue going to Costco. They have cheap pizza and free samples prepared by delightful seniors. Besides, if you hired someone, they'd never buy the right kind of coffee.

You can address this problem head on and bring in a studio manager or a project manager. This hire would have clear responsibilities, and they would likely take

DON'T LOOK BACK NOW:

“Everyone I know who has hired a project manager has never gone back. But it’s hard not to see it as non-billable overhead.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

the most busy work off your plate. As they spend more time with the studio their responsibilities can grow accordingly. Make sure they have enough work to do (if they don’t, consider hiring part-time). This starts with a clear job description. As they get more familiar and efficient with the work in front of them be ready to expand their responsibilities.

Hire a recent graduate or very junior creative person who is willing to take on office manager responsibilities. During the times when they aren’t keeping the office running smoothly they can be learning the ropes on the creative side of the business.

Hire a junior creative person who can help with creative work. Of these options, this is probably the one I see happening the most. I also believe it's one of the least effective. Managing and teaching this person tends to replace any time you would have hoped to gain.

Bring in a strong, qualified creative who can take serious work off your shoulders. This likely has the biggest effect on the output of your studio but it also costs the most money and is the hardest person to hire as a small studio. You need someone who will complement your existing team and be able to run projects with minimal oversight. Plus, they need to be OK going on Costco runs with you assuming you don't hire an office manager first. Bonus points if they have a truck.

KEEP YOUR SANITY:

“As a one-person operation you can only do so many things in a year and keep yourself sane. In the first year I took everything that came my way and I was miserable.”

—MIKEY BURTON

No matter who you hire, make sure you know how this hire affects your growth plan. Be able to complete these sentences:

I am hiring _____ to be responsible for _____

_____ .

These responsibilities are currently with _____

This will free them up to handle _____

_____ .

This is not to say that you will know everything your new hire will ultimately be responsible for. Two of the most senior people at A Hundred Monkeys started as office managers. You do, however, need to know what you are hiring them to do and what this will free others to do. While responsibilities can and should change over time, you need to be clear about what they are initially. This ensures that your new hire knows where they fit in and knows what they need to do in order to be successful and play an important role in the studio. Do not create a job description as you go along. If you don't clearly set expectations it will be hard for everyone, including you and the person you're hiring, to know if they're making the grade. When it comes time for their first review, you will have a clear guide.

The act of hiring itself can be a very ad hoc procedure. You meet someone, you look at their resume and portfolio, you like them, you tell someone else to meet them, you two talk about it, and decide if you want to hire them or not. If you aren't clear on what you're looking for you will never know when you find it. Here are some simple ways to get the most out the hiring process:

Create a scorecard

What are the qualities, abilities, and qualifications you're looking for most in a new hire? Create a simple scorecard that you can

review while you're interviewing or right after. If you're interviewing multiple candidates this gives you the ability to compare them directly on the criteria that matters to you. More important skills or qualities can be given more points. This is by no means a be-all end-all scenario. Your gut feeling of a person is important. This is just an effective way to check the boxes you need to check.

Share a meal

This is a good way to learn about how someone communicates with people they don't know too well. If you're envisioning this new hire meeting clients one day, this scenario should play out on a regular basis. Are they capable of small talk? Can they drive a conversation? Give them ample opportunity to move the conversation and see where they take it. Save any interview-type questions you might want to ask for the end. It's also interesting to see how they interact with the restaurant staff. Are they polite? Can they quickly build a rapport? While these qualities might not be essential for you, they might be some of your best clues to how your potential hire might interact with clients and others in the studio. At the very least, it's a pretty good way to tell if you enjoy spending time around someone.

Be prepared: Read their resumé again right before you meet them so you don't have to be looking down at a sheet of paper the whole

time. Ask questions you actually want to know the answers to instead of what just happens to come up. You probably aren't going to learn too much in an interview where you talk about your favorite restaurants half the time.

Describe the job as accurately as you can

Be sure to include all of the unattractive and difficult parts, and at the end ask directly if they want to do it. Read their reaction. Listen to the language they use in their response. Are they excited about the job or are they just willing to do it? Ask questions to understand their motivations and what they're looking for in their career. Most people are looking for a job that fits them, not the other way around. Others just really want a job and would eagerly accept almost anything put in front of them. If they sound overly excited about doing dishes or ordering supplies, they probably aren't in it for the long haul. There's nothing wrong with wanting a job really bad. You just want to make sure they really want the job you're offering instead of a job in general.

Hire on a trial basis (if you can)

Different states, and countries, have their own rules about this but if there's a legal way to hire on a trial basis initially, you get the opportunity to work with someone extensively before committing to hiring them full time. Four to six weeks should be

ROTTEN APPLES:

“At a small studio if you have two people who don’t really get along, that can spill over to the whole studio.”

—CHRISTIAN SCHWARTZ, COMMERCIAL TYPE

enough time to know if someone is going to be a good fit or not. This can end up being mutually beneficial as your new hire also gets a chance to see if the company is a good fit for them. If they’re doing a great job — great! They’re off to running start. If it’s not working out, there’s a built-in time to end the relationship. They have been paid for the work they’ve done to date and hopefully there are no hard feelings.

Keep a personnel file on everyone who works at the studio.

This is important from an HR perspective, but it’s even more useful for helping people improve. You’re interacting with these people every day and when you notice them developing a new skill or incorporating feedback well or messing something up, it usually isn’t worth it to bring everything to a grinding halt and address it. While immediate

feedback is certainly valuable, having a place for notes and thoughts on the development of people in your studio can be a valuable resource. It certainly makes it easier when it comes time to review everyone's performance. It's also a great way to track their personal growth: After you discuss something to improve, has this improvement been incorporated the next time you sit down. Without these notes each employee review becomes an ad hoc discussion that likely misses key observations and ideas for improvement. Bringing up positive changes you've seen is also a great way to show that you recognize and appreciate hard work.

Lastly, make sure to have Non-Disclosure/Confidentiality Agreements and employment agreements with all employees.

This is a simple, practical step you can take that will one day save your ass. Without these agreements in place you aren't protected against all sorts of stuff:

- Employees who go to competitors and tell everything
- Employees who like to impress dates by talking about clients
- Employees who steal your intellectual property
- Employees who share confidential work with the media
- Contractors who claim they're employees

The list goes on!

BAND TOGETHER:

“I hire people that creatively inspire me. I’m looking for people who will be able to work well together and complement each other. It’s a gut feeling initially but you find out pretty quick.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

Now, I know what you’re going to say: I trust the people who work for me! They would never do anything like that! You’re probably right. There is no need to be paranoid and defensive about this stuff. The vast majority of people have good intentions and would never intentionally harm the studio or its clients. This doesn’t mean you shouldn’t protect your studio to the best of your ability. Having people sign these agreements is the easiest and best way to put these concerns to bed. Go over them with anyone you hire and make sure they understand and have a chance to ask any questions. Get everything signed off and filed away. Hopefully you will never need them again.

ATTITUDE OVER STYLE:

“We have a specific style. If we were 20 people, our style would be different, more diverse. There are definitely some differences between the people at Hey but I’m looking for the same attitude. Not a duplicate of what we’re doing but I’m looking for the same sense of design.”

I have included a sample non-disclosure agreement (runstudiorun.com/resources). If you use it you will need to read it over carefully and adjust for your specific situation and location. If you're unsure, spend an hour with a good employment attorney to get it right. The National Employment Lawyers Association is a good resource (website: nela.org) and most states have their own associations as well.

Firing people feels awful. I've fired five employees and it felt like a mini, painful breakup every time. Looking back on these situations, the most common reason I had to fire people was that I shouldn't have hired them in the first place. I missed the red flags. Not wanting to fire people was all the motivation I needed to put more energy into hiring. People's work and lives are so intertwined. You shouldn't hire someone because "they'll do." You should hire people because you feel strongly that they can make a meaningful contribution to your studio and will grow their skillset along the way.

15

Best the best

Know who you're really competing with

Who are you really competing with?
When you lose projects to competitors, do everything you can to find out who you lost to and why from the client. I know this can feel embarrassing, like your middle school crush doesn't want to dance with you, but it's important.



Catalog this data and see if you can come to any conclusions. Your competition might not look like you. You could be losing projects to one-woman shops or you could be losing projects to worldwide firms who have a small practice in your focus area.

Keep tabs on how your competition communicates and markets themselves. This shouldn't take more than 15 minutes, once or twice a year. You're doing this to make sure you stand out and know how to differentiate yourself over the phone and in a meeting. The question "How are you different from other studios?" comes up way too often for you not to have a good answer. Not only that, studios change their teams and positioning and processes enough that you need to make sure how you're different is still how you're different. Be careful not to fixate on your competition — this drives homogeneity. As long as you aren't looking and sounding like everyone else, going off on your own and really diving headfirst into the work you want to do will yield more interesting results.

When you're speaking with a potential client, ask questions that allow you to understand their motivations and fears. Know how the project they're proposing fits in with their bigger strategy. From there, think about how your firm is uniquely suited to help them. If in the course of asking these questions you figure out that you aren't well suited to the project,

instead of trying to win the work just to win, try one of these things:

- Be honest and tell them why the project isn't a great fit for you. They will appreciate the honesty and if they come across a project that does fit, they will get back in touch knowing you're well suited for the job. Part of this responsibility is on you to maintain contact with the client over time to keep your firm top of mind.
- Carve out a portion of the project that you would be in a strong position to work on. Explain how it's important to work with specialists and it's difficult to specialize in marketing, design, and implementation (pick your own variables). You're much better off designing a project you feel confident about executing, even if they say no.

JUST ASK:

“I ask now. If they don't go with me I ask how much the winning bid was. Oftentimes it's half which is crazy but some of these people are in small cities where they can afford to price projects cheaper.”

—MIKEY BURTON

“I’ve worked in larger agencies and smaller ones. The big difference is the level of scrutiny on design. You have so much more control when you’re small. You’re sourcing paper and other materials. It’s hands on. At a larger agency that’s the responsibility of the production person. There’s a real sense of accountability when you control the process.”

OUT WITH THE OLD:

“Most of the graphic designers we talk to have a lot more experience with screen printing than letterpress. There was this stigma that letterpress was an older, more stuffy, process. A lot of old-school printers don’t want to give you the time of day. We really wanted to break out of that and do something fun and contemporary.”

—JENNY PAN, THE WEEKEND PRESS

At A Hundred Monkeys, we list all of our competition on our site. This is one way in which we’re different. Over the years we have had several competitors ask to be added to the site. We happily oblige. It has turned into a de facto naming industry directory. We do this because we truly believe our work product is different than our competitors and there’s no way to prove that without inviting everyone to see for themselves. If someone finds a competitor through our site and likes their work better, great. Unless you’re struggling to stay afloat you should only want to work with people who want to work with you. No new client is under the impression that you’re the only company in the creative industry. So why pretend like that’s the case? Be proud of why you’re different and recognize the projects and clients that truly suit you. Strong-arming people into hiring you is not a winning strategy for anyone in this business.

16

Throwing numbers around

Negotiating with
your goals front
and center

To most people,
negotiation feels
arbitrary. That's
because a lot of it is.
If a project is profitable
for you, what's the
reason it costs
\$40,000 instead
of \$50,000?



How do you know a competitor won't underbid you to get a project even though it will lose them money? (Stop worrying about it. You have zero control over this.) Negotiation should be a function of your goals. If you took 50 of the project you're about to sign, would you have a growing, thriving business, or would you work yourself into the ground? Remember the cupcake example? Mmm, discount cupcakes.

Assuming a project won't lose you money, negotiate with your goals front and center. As we discussed in "Is this project worth your time?" if you have a good sense that a project will be profitable for you, you have a very clearly defined negotiating floor. This calculation looks roughly something like this: Based on past projects I believe this project will take X percentage of my availability over Y period of time. That equals \$Z per month. I need \$A per month in order to stay afloat and \$B per month to hit my yearly goals. Given how excited I am about the project, what level of profitability am I OK with? Once you hit your goals, you will be able to negotiate a lot more freely. You can be much more discerning and only take projects that are clearly profitable with clients that fit the long-term goals of your business.

It's a lot easier to negotiate if you have a good relationship with the person you're negotiating with. If you put a proposal on the table that's too expensive for a client, what is the likelihood that they'll come back to you with a counter

offer? If they like you — pretty high. If you use the conversations before a proposal to build the foundation of a relationship, the chance that they'll come back willing to negotiate is greater. Spending some time getting to know the client means you can price a project more profitably and know that if it's outside the client's budget they will at least come back to the table willing to negotiate. This is why some studios work with the client to "co-create" a brief before a proposal. You get an opportunity to build rapport and show your value before they see the price tag. There's obviously the risk that you're wasting your time but if it's a project you really want, this isn't wasted time at all. If a project is profitable for you and the client wants to work with you there's no reason you shouldn't be able to find a way to make the project happen.

CHECK YOUR ASSUMPTIONS:

"It's great to have friends and colleagues from other studios who you can bounce ideas off of and figure out if you're pricing something right or what your expenses on a project should be."

-EMILY TU, TUNG

NO FORCED ENTRY:

“Some clients might just not be ready to buy the work. That’s OK. Don’t force it. They’ll come back when they’re ready.”

—JJ KAYE, HIGH PRESSURE ZONE

Conversely, this is why RFPs (requests for proposals) are such a waste of time. The process is essentially designed to be transactional and to put all participants on even competitive footing. They want to look at the bids in an apples-to-apples way so they tend to be very structured about what information they’re giving you. You might not even know what you’re bidding on. They also typically see any deviation from what they are asking for as an unnecessary complication instead of sharing fresh ideas or thinking differently. Knowing the process is competitive also pushes some studios to bid very low. At A Hundred Monkeys

we categorically do not provide proposals in response to RFPs. Instead we kindly say that we appreciate the request and if they ever decide that they'd like to work with us we would love to hear from them. Sometimes they come back. Sometimes they don't. Either way we unceremoniously throw the RFP in the trashcan. Then we light some balsam fir incense and perform an incantation. OK, I guess it was more ceremonious than I had previously thought. Sorry.

Agreeing on scope, timing, and deliverables is another important component of negotiation. Again, the more familiar you are with your process, the more you'll understand what you can be flexible on and what you can't compromise. Some clients will do anything they can to shorten the timeline. This is understandable. We all have our own timelines to be responsible for. Never let the timeline or specific scope meaningfully compromise your work. If the project ends poorly, they won't blame the timeline or the scope, they'll blame you. And they should. No one is going to protect your process and your timeline but you. It's important to know where to draw the line in the sand. Like a lot of things this sometimes means crossing that line and remembering never to do so again. We've all been there. Live and learn.

Don't negotiate against yourself. Never counter your own proposal before hearing a substantive response from the client. If they're looking to

do the project for less money, what's something that you can ask for in return? Meetings over video conference? A delayed start to accommodate your schedule? The ability to thoroughly document the project for an interactive case study? It's a negotiation, not a capitulation. The client needs to understand that if you're doing the project for less money, they need to figure out a way to make the project more efficient or attractive for your studio. Again, if they are unmoved by your attempts, they're viewing you as a commodity and this is likely a relatively undesirable project.

DON'T BUDGE:

“There are some aspects of what we do that are non-negotiable because they negatively affect the work. We can’t let clients eliminate key aspects of our process. We put those things there for a reason and that’s because we’re looking out for the end result. If a client doesn’t want to pay for us to understand their business, the project isn’t going to work. I know the project won’t be successful. It’ll be mired with miscommunication and problems. The client won’t be happy, we won’t be happy. The only way we can do work in service of your business is if we understand your business. This takes time and energy.”

Pay attention to the terms and conditions of every single project you take on. Just because you have a handshake (or email) agreement to do a project for a price, this means nothing until you have a signed agreement. This is important because certain terms mean that a project isn't worth taking at any price. Specific terms like indemnity can literally end up shutting down your business. A lot of these agreements are drafted to be as broad as possible to defend the client. There is nothing unusual about this. It's the job of the client's lawyers to protect them at all costs. It's your job (and that of your lawyers, if you have them) to protect you at all costs. A lot of this broad-reaching language might be applicable for partners who are doing things like writing code or setting up hardware infrastructure. You need to understand what these terms mean relative to the work you're providing. If you don't understand what something means for your studio, ask the client to clarify or have an attorney read it over for you and make suggestions. This will likely cost less than \$500 which is absolutely worth it for most projects. Some (definitely not all, depending on what specifically your studio does) of the terms to watch out for are:

Work approval

This means that the client has the right to reject or approve the work you provide. This type of clause makes sense if you're contracted to set up a phone system and it doesn't work.

For creative work, however, they could say they don't like the strategy you create or the logos you design and pay you nothing. Some work approval clauses state that the client can do this "at any time," meaning you could finish a project and then get nothing because the client decides they don't like what you did.

Indemnity

This is the single most dangerous clause that ends up in contracts on a regular basis. Indemnity means that if some company comes after your client for the work you did, you will take full legal responsibility and indemnify your client from any legal wrongdoing. Again, this makes sense if you're providing code for your client's website and they want to make sure you aren't stealing any of it.

IT'S ALL NEGOTIABLE:

"Negotiation can take a variety of paths. When a lot of people say negotiation, they hear 'money.' You can negotiate on deliverables, scope. You can throw in a little extra work so they really feel like they're getting that value."

If you run a web design studio, this clause could make sense if it's specifically applied to the code you're providing. But big companies sue each other all the time for all sorts of reasons. They have massive legal teams both internally and on retainer. Some companies even threaten legal action without a real case just because they have the resources to bully a smaller company. If you're providing logos or names or illustrations, they have the resources and ability to check if there are any potential legal issues pertaining to their business. So please, avoid indemnity clauses. And if you must have them, make sure you're specific about what they apply to. Agreeing that you will never knowingly use copyrighted material is a lot different than agreeing to take a bullet for a big company because they're being sued. At A Hundred Monkeys we run into a handful of indemnity clauses in contracts every year. Honestly, it's the first thing I look for when reading over a contract. Sometimes it takes a few emails or phone calls to get it removed but we've never lost a project because of it.

Milestones

Be careful where and when the milestones for a project are. Payments are often tied to milestones so make sure you're getting paid in time to cover your expenses. If you have a lot of projects running concurrently this might not be such a big issue but if you're counting on having the money at a certain point make

sure there are no big obstacles to getting there. Oftentimes clients can run into internal roadblocks. (“We can’t get in front of leadership yet.” “We’re waiting to hear back from our research partners.” The list goes on.) These stoppages can be a major wrench in the works, especially if you can’t invoice them until you’ve hit the milestones you’ve agreed on.

Work ownership

Some studios feel strongly about this and others don’t. Most boilerplate client contracts state that they assume ownership over all work provided. If you’re OK with this, fine. If the goal of the project is to get to a specific solution, why should they retain ownership to everything else? This is a good point of negotiation, so if the client feels strongly about assuming rights to all work, this could be a good reason to up the price. If they get more work, you should get more money. Or an all-expenses paid trip to Tahiti. I’m not going to sit here and underestimate your negotiating capabilities.

Negotiation is all about setting your studio up for success. You need the time, compensation, and conditions to make the project a successful one for both you and the client. If you go into a negotiation knowing what you really need as well as what you want, there’s nothing to be afraid of or intimidated by. If you don’t get what you need, walk away. If you don’t get what you want, work to find the middle ground.

17

Talking in circles

How to communicate
with your team

How you communicate with your team can either be an all-consuming time drain or a productive system that keeps people in the know and allows you and other team members to be more effective while not physically in the office. The key here is restraint.



Unless you can exercise impressive restraint, the likes of which I don't think I've ever seen in an office environment, do not use email as a primary method of communicating with your team. Yes, there was a time where this was the main way work got done. Also, yes, this time has come and gone. Email is for communicating with clients — and even that seems to be on the way out. I tend to block off three small windows of the day for email. Spending any more time refreshing your inbox is a big waste of time.

I know, you want to be responsive. No, you do not need to be that responsive. It's nice to get that little dopamine hit when you get a new message. Dopamine is stimulated by unpredictability and not knowing when you're going to get that next important email is perfect bait. Research by Kent Berridge and Terry Robinson of the University of Michigan shows that the dopamine system does not have satiety built in. This means you will always want more and never be satisfied. It feels productive when you respond to email when it comes in but it's easy for email to end up swallowing your whole day. When and how quickly you respond to email trains the expectations of the people you correspond with. If you respond immediately, day or night, that is what will be expected of you. If you do anything different you wouldn't be meeting the expectation you have set. Do not set this expectation. And if you have set this expectation, gradually (over a month or so) transition to responding to email in batches.

Through the process of doing this for myself I did not receive a single negative comment about my response time or availability. Most people would be amazed at how much of their days they spend in their inboxes. Learn to put it away — minimize the window or even log out if the craving for that sweet sweet new email is proving too strong. Then, when it's time to give your full attention to email you will be amazed at how quickly you can power through it.

NO ONE PAYS YOU TO EMAIL:

“I get mad at myself when I spend too much time doing email. It's an unsatisfying time suck. You just get mad at yourself when you realize you completely annihilate a day with email. I really like using the Pomodoro Technique. It helps me a lot with email because it cuts me off. OK, the timer has told me I have to stop. The built-in breaks are helpful, too. I also have this app called Freedom that blocks off different websites and social media. I do this because I'm a child and I need an app to block myself from visiting sites that I go to all the time.”

—KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

Slack (as well as Stride and other real-time communication tools) is a much more effective way to communicate with your team. You can have “channels” for every project as well as internal projects and efforts. I’m not going to be too prescriptive about how to use these applications but they offer a lot of great features like reminders, private channels, Do Not Disturb, and alerts that makes communication seamless whether you’re in the office or out. Compared to an email inbox that’s crudely threaded at best, these tools make it easy to keep tabs on what’s going on.

The main drawback of these real-time communication tools is that alerts and chat are built for immediate response. They’re very easy to get sucked into and you can just as easily waste a bunch of time chatting with your team as you can browsing Reddit and BuzzFeed. Be conscientious about the communication culture you create and make sure you allow time for people to be untethered and actually get some thinking done. Make use of Do Not Disturb, muting, and other features that prevent these tools from becoming constant annoyances. You do not need a pop-up whenever someone posts a YouTube video to your #Random channel. The same goes for text message alerts and any other notifications that you receive on your phone and computer while you’re working. Don’t be driven by distraction. Work to limit the interruptions, however brief they may be, that can take your mind off of what you’ve decided

I'LL BE THERE:

“I want to instill confidence in clients that I’ll be able to deliver but I also don’t want them to think they have 24-7 access to me. I’m available when I’m available and as long as I’m upfront about it there aren’t really any issues.”

—KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

to work on. Again, the dopamine system is especially sensitive to visual and auditory cues that indicate a “reward” is about happen. These cues can turn into a nonstop distraction. You don’t need them. Turn them off. Creativity and being always available are natural enemies in many ways.

It is very possible to overcommunicate. While this might be better than undercommunicating, don’t reward or praise people for being active in these channels. Pay close attention to the difference between what it looks like when people are getting shit done vs what it looks like when people are communicating a lot. Activity does not equal productivity.

18

Meetings that aren't soul crushing

Easier than you think

Need to check in on a project? Have a meeting. Need to plan how you're going to build a proposal? Have a meeting. Need to research a client's competition? Have a meeting. Meetings have turned into a workplace catchall.



Since we're all busy and we need to make sure that work for specific projects gets done, scheduling meetings acts as a way to block off time on your calendar to move work forward. So, when you ask yourself, "When am I going to get to [insert project]?" you can confidently look at your calendar and say "11 a.m. on Thursday." The problem is, meetings are a really ineffective way to move work forward. You get a few people in a room, recap what you already know, share some thoughts and questions, inevitably get off topic, and you end up basically where you started. Maybe you'll assign someone a task and set another meeting to check in again. It's a vicious cycle.

Now, I know I'm not the first or thousandth person to rail against meetings. Everyone seems to have a sense that they're ineffective, but what are you going to do about it? All internal meetings that make it onto your calendar should meet three criteria. Yes, this will make it a little harder to schedule meetings. That's the point.

A purpose: All meetings should have a purpose. What, specifically, would you like to leave the meeting with? If you, or whoever is scheduling the meeting, can't articulate what the end result should be, do not have the meeting. Either wait until you have that clarity or just move on with the rest of your life. Every time you decide not to have a meeting an angel gets its wings.

An agenda: Whoever wants to have a meeting needs to outline the agenda for the meeting. I find it's best when these outlines make their way into the calendar invite. Whoever schedules a meeting is responsible for its success. When a meeting has an agenda, everyone knows what you're going to address and in what order. This is a time saver more than anything else. You can work through the points and often end meetings early, which everyone seems to get excited about. If people start talking about what they're watching on Netflix or this article in *The New York Times*, your meeting is a waste of *Times*.

WHERE THE RUBBER MEETS THE ROAD:

“I’m really not satisfied with our schedule of internal meetings. When do you bring everyone in? When do you put the computers away? When do you take something out of someone’s hands because you know it needs to get done and they might not get there?”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

JUST CHECKING:

“What I’m criticized the most about as a boss is people wanting more check-ins. They want to make sure they’re on the right track. This is why we’ve built quality control checkpoints throughout the process.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

An ask: What do people need to bring to the meeting? Is there work they need to do in order for the meeting to be productive? The more specific you can be here the better but even if you’re just asking for someone’s presence, let them know.

Even within the creative process structured meetings are helpful. There’s plenty of room for exploration during the meeting itself. The important thing is that you define what you’re looking to get out of it.

Meetings with clients certainly benefit from this structure as well but you have their meeting culture to consider. If you're leading the meeting, sharing an agenda and working to make sure everyone comes to the meeting knowing what will be asked of them makes you look professional and prepared.

Pay attention to how your clients act in your meetings and adjust accordingly. If they're clacking away on their pocket computers, you probably need to do a little more to keep their attention. Maybe they respond better to discussions than presentations. Maybe they're more interested in your thought process than the final product. Figure out a way to get them engaged in the work. Sometimes this is easy and other times it takes trial and error. They're called presentations but don't let the name lock you into an *I talk, you listen* format. It's up to you to find a way to make meetings productive and engaging. Some of these adjustments can easily be made on the fly, in meetings themselves, while others will take some time away in order to formulate the best approach.

When you're meeting with clients, make sure you work hard for your good work. Don't shy away from putting your point of view on the table clearly and confidently. In good client relationships, the client values your point of view as much or more than they value the work itself. No they don't take every recommendation but there should be no ambiguity as to which

“For a while we had everyone in all meetings, partly to include everyone in the process, partly to make sure everyone got the information for a project first hand. I’d been at too many places where details or intent was lost in translation going from the client to an account director to the creative director to the design team. This works in some cases, but we found the entire team’s time was being wasted. Now we’re very intentional with meetings. No one is in a meeting that doesn’t need to be, and we download everyone as soon as the meeting is over to make sure the details are conveyed properly. This is also increasing productivity because when we’re not in meetings we can get more design work done.”

option is strongest. Also, never ever put work on the table that you wouldn't proudly promote. If presenting work is some sort of minefield where you're hoping the client doesn't pick the wrong option, you're doing it wrong. Secure delete the work you don't want them to pick. Only share work you're proud of.

No matter what type of meeting you're about to head into, know what you're looking to get out of it. This saves everyone time and helps move work forward. If you don't know what you're looking to get out of a meeting, make a meeting with yourself to figure it out.

19

Who what when

**Keep your projects
running like clockwork**

Having established process for projects makes planning a lot easier. Be sure to visually keep track of all delivery and presentation dates. We use a big roll of butcher paper that's mounted to the wall and updated weekly.



This makes it easy for everyone in the office to see potential timing conflicts with meetings/deliverables before they occur. While we still use Google Calendar for everything, we find that conflicts are easier to spot on paper. Look out for these conflicts and know what your team's limits are. How many presentations can you actually do in a day? How many projects can kick off on the same week? If you ever find yourself on the other side of these limits, write it down and remember it next time you're about to schedule your third presentation on a Friday.

If you've reached your limits and you aren't planning on hiring to meet demand, you either need to raise your prices or start to schedule projects out in the future. This has a double benefit in that you avoid rush projects (more on those in a sec) and you have future work and income you can count on. If clients really want to work with you, most of the time they will be willing to wait a few weeks. If they truly can't wait, they'll remember to reach out earlier next time, which benefits everyone involved.

ALL BOOKED UP:

“When we're busy we push out our schedule. If they don't have a fixed timeline or if they really want to work with us we can push out the timeline to a point where we can take it on.”

-EMILY TU, TUNG

PLANNING UNDER PRESSURE:

“I’m actually able to be more productive when I have more things to do. I have to be efficient with my time and that pressure makes me a better planner.”

—KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

Figuring out how much work you’re going to put into a project is always an exercise in estimation. You might not figure out that your client is a talker until you’ve had a few meetings. That’s OK. There is a level of unpredictability inherent in all projects. The tough part is delivery dates are often quite firm. This isn’t an exercise in perfection — it’s an exercise in time management. Of course, if you don’t have a set range of offerings and find yourself custom tailoring a majority of your projects, estimating time becomes significantly more difficult. This is one of the many reasons why limiting your offering is good for business. This doesn’t solve for unpredictability but it significantly limits and helps you adjust for it.

STICK TO THE SPECIFICS:

“When it comes to something new that we may not be so familiar with we like to break things up a bit more. We use separate phases as their own billable portions. Websites, for example, can be such huge projects with lots of moving parts and pieces. After pricing out the first stage we’re in a good place to price out the rest of the project more accurately. We give a ballpark for the whole project so there aren’t big surprises. Being very specific in your proposal and cost estimates allows you and the client to easily see when something falls outside of scope. It’s important to set expectations.”

-EMILY TU, TUNG

When clients want work done quickly, it’s more important to plan specifically what needs to get done by when. If you’re just condensing your process, you and your studiomates are likely going to need to spend the same number of hours on a project in less overall time. This lowers your bandwidth for other projects. Can you afford to do that? Will you be staying late to make that happen? Keeping an up-to-date calendar and employing schedule blocking make it easy to see these conflicts on your calendar before they actually become conflicts.

Another way to approach the situation is to bargain with the client. If they want something in two weeks that normally takes four, what are you getting in exchange for that on-demand availability? Sure, you could ask for more money but if you're busy and trying to make sure all of your clients are taken care of, maybe you're presenting three concepts instead of five. Maybe you're presenting over video conference instead of traveling. If you end up doing the same amount of work in half the time for the same amount of money, you're just showing the client that they can wait until the last minute to hire you. If they keep working with you there will likely always be a rush. Projects take a certain amount of time for a reason, and that reason should factor in the reality of working on more than one project at a time. Don't let your immediate attention be a free resource.

SCHEDULE IN REALITY:

“It’s really easy to create this idealized schedule of what you think you can do but then there’s the reality of what actually happens. It’s easy to beat yourself up over blowing an insane idealized schedule.”

—KATE BINGAMAN-BURT

20

The books

**Don't pretend to be
an accountant**

A professional
bookkeeper should
play an important
part in your studio.
Find someone who is
patient and will work
with you. This should
not be a “talk to me
before April 15th”
type of relationship.



Most creative people are allergic to accounting. This is fine as long as you have a good relationship with someone who takes responsibility for all this work and keeps you in the loop. Being blind to the numbers behind your studio leads to “surprises” and not the “I got a car for my Sweet 16!” kind. No, accounting surprises tend to end with conversations about why we had to let Stuart go (sorry, Stuart), and explaining why people aren’t getting bonuses this year. Nobody likes accounting surprises, and hiding from them because you went to art school isn’t a good excuse.

Find an accountant you trust, who has experience with creative agencies and other professional service firms who will meet with you for at least an hour every quarter and keep you up to date on the financials of your business. Bonus points if they use Xero or QuickBooks Online and you can see all of this stuff in a live dashboard.

Side note: Speaking of putting your financial data in the cloud, for the love of everything you consider holy, use good information security practices. Use long, complex passwords and change them at least yearly. Using a password manager will make this easier. You are likely accruing a lot of sensitive, confidential information (your clients’ and your own) and you do not want it to fall into the wrong hands because you think your password is secure using 3s for Es and 4s for As. I could really dive

in deep here but I'm going to avoid the urge and refer you to this EFF Surveillance Self-Defense guide (<https://ssd.eff.org>). Certain clients will require you to have specific security protocols in place but you should really be doing this anyway. I know this can be slightly annoying but it is very much worth it. Make sure your site, your email, your banking, your accounting, and just about anything else important you keep online is protected by a very secure password. Use two-factor authentication if it's an option. Don't give real life answers to security questions. OK, I have digressed enough.

BE BOOK SMART:

“Every book I’ve read and founder I’ve talked to told me to get someone to take care of the books and accounting first. We talked to people around San Francisco about who they worked with, contacted a few and found someone who worked with other studios like us so they were familiar with our world. We have been able to set up the business in a way that, by ourselves, we never would have been able to.”

—BRENT COUCHMAN, MONIKER

“If I could have done one thing differently it would have been hiring a bookkeeper sooner. I had been doing the bookkeeping so there was this backlog of work when we got busy. I didn’t get into this business to be a bookkeeper, it’s just something that needed to get done and when you’re small there’s no one else to do it. It’s important to understand how bookkeeping works (How can we expense things? How will this affect our taxes?), but having someone who can do it properly takes a huge weight off our shoulders. As we take on more work we need to be conscientious about what we choose to do ourselves.”

Be on a schedule with a fastidious bookkeeper who can coordinate with your accountant in your absence. Some bookkeepers work remotely and have you send them all your scanned receipts. Others come into the office every week or two and sort through your mangled receipts and invoices. There are also apps and other tools like Receipt Bank and the unfortunately named Expensify that can help you keep your bookkeeping under control. Bookkeeping is obviously something you don't want to spend a lot of time doing so invest in the tools and the partners that prevent you from wasting time digging under the seat of your car for an airport parking receipt. Having a system saves you time and headaches.

Considering revenue projections are just that, projections, it's important to keep a cash reserve of at least three months worth of expenses. This means that if you have a bad quarter or lose a big client or something else goes sideways, you're prepared and won't need to make drastic changes right away. (Remember Stuart?) Reserves give you time to diagnose issues and deal with them properly, without any panic.

Work with your bookkeeper and accountant to understand the cash flow pattern of your business. Just because you signed a new project, doesn't mean you're getting paid right away. You need to have consistent cash flow or big reserves in order to make sure you can

pay all of your expenses while you wait for the money from that big new project you signed. Have standard payment terms that work for your cash flow and modify them as needed. Payment structure should almost never lead to you not taking a project. Typically, with smaller clients you can dictate terms and with larger ones getting even a small adjustment can be impossible. If there's a way to get some cash up front, always do it.

Another thing that studios tend to spend a lot of money on is their office space. If the majority of your clients are local and/or willing to come to you, having a fancy office makes some sense. In a way, you're trading the time and costs of some travel for having an office that people are excited to visit. If you do travel a fair amount or have a lot of meetings at clients' offices, having an office in a trendy part of town with beautiful furniture is probably a waste of money. I'm not saying that your office should be a dump in a strip mall. Please, have a nice office that people in your studio feel comfortable in and new hires would be excited to show up at. Just don't overspend because you're a designer and you want everything to be perfect.

We could really dive into the weeds here but there are myriad different ways to set up your entity, accounting, and bookkeeping apparatus. Work with an accountant and bookkeeper to set up a structure that you understand and can stay on top of. Make sure your big expenses aren't big for superficial reasons.

21

You are your portfolio

**For clients,
seeing is believing**

The majority of clients are not creative. That's why they're hiring you. The work you create for them is your most potent business development tool.



This is the case for two reasons.

Happy clients are the number one source of good, new leads. They can hire you again and they can tell their friends. If every client has the potential to grow your network, what sort of network are you trying to grow? One with clients who call you a “vendor” and start conversations with “We have zero budget for this”? Or clients who love your work, see its value, and want to tell everyone they know? (Pick the second one.)

New clients that show up at your door without a direct referral are basing a lot of their decision to hire you on the work in your portfolio. No matter how much you say that every project is its own unique snowflake, tailored to the specific and exacting needs of every client, that’s too much ambiguity for non-creative-types. They see something you’ve already done and say “I’ll have one of those please. Just put my logo where you have that other one.”

BUILD A CULT FOLLOWING:

“Your work begets your work. We’ve learned to be OK with not getting some projects. The ones that click are the ones that click from the start. The people reaching out now are, 90 percent of the time, looking for systems.”

—BOBBY MARTIN, OCD

I'LL HAVE WHAT SHE'S HAVING:

“People see something and they know that they want it. It’s hard to imagine how something is going to turn out, especially with print. What tends to happen is people see something they like and want something similar for themselves.”

—JENNY PAN, THE WEEKEND PRESS

If there are types of projects that you want to do or industries you want to be in, find a way to make it happen. This doesn’t mean you need a big-name client to get into it. When the right opportunity knocks, make sure to give it everything you have. Don’t treat your golden opportunity like just another project. Over-deliver. Make sure it’s clear to them that you’ve done your research and you’re truly passionate about the project. This should be second nature if you’re actually excited about the work. Make it so that if they ever have a need in the general vicinity of work you’re good at, they call you immediately.

Also, just because you did a project, doesn’t mean it needs to be a part of your portfolio. Even though it seems counterintuitive, your portfolio is more about the work you want than the work you’ve already done.

The Frozen Mango Problem:

Client: Have you ever done any design in the food/beverage space?

You: Yes, yes we have.

Client: Great. Have you ever worked on a project with fruits and vegetables?

You: Actually, yeah, once or twice.

Client: Perfect. What about frozen fruit?

You: Maybe, I'll have to check.

Client: Got it. Last question: have you ever done a frozen mango project before?

You: Uhm, can't say we have. Is that a thing?

Client: Sorry, we're really looking for someone with specific experience in our market.

Is this an exaggeration? Sure. But we all know it happens. The frozen mango industry is notoriously conservative. Having a portfolio that reflects the work you want to be doing is the best way to ensure you keep getting the work you want to be doing. It's the circle of life. Well, not life, but it's definitely the circle of running creative studios.

STAY READY:

“If work is slower, I add a personal project to keep my practice and structure going. The wheels are turning that way. I find if you're starting and stopping cold, it's harder to get into that creative space where you're prolific and making work you're proud of.”

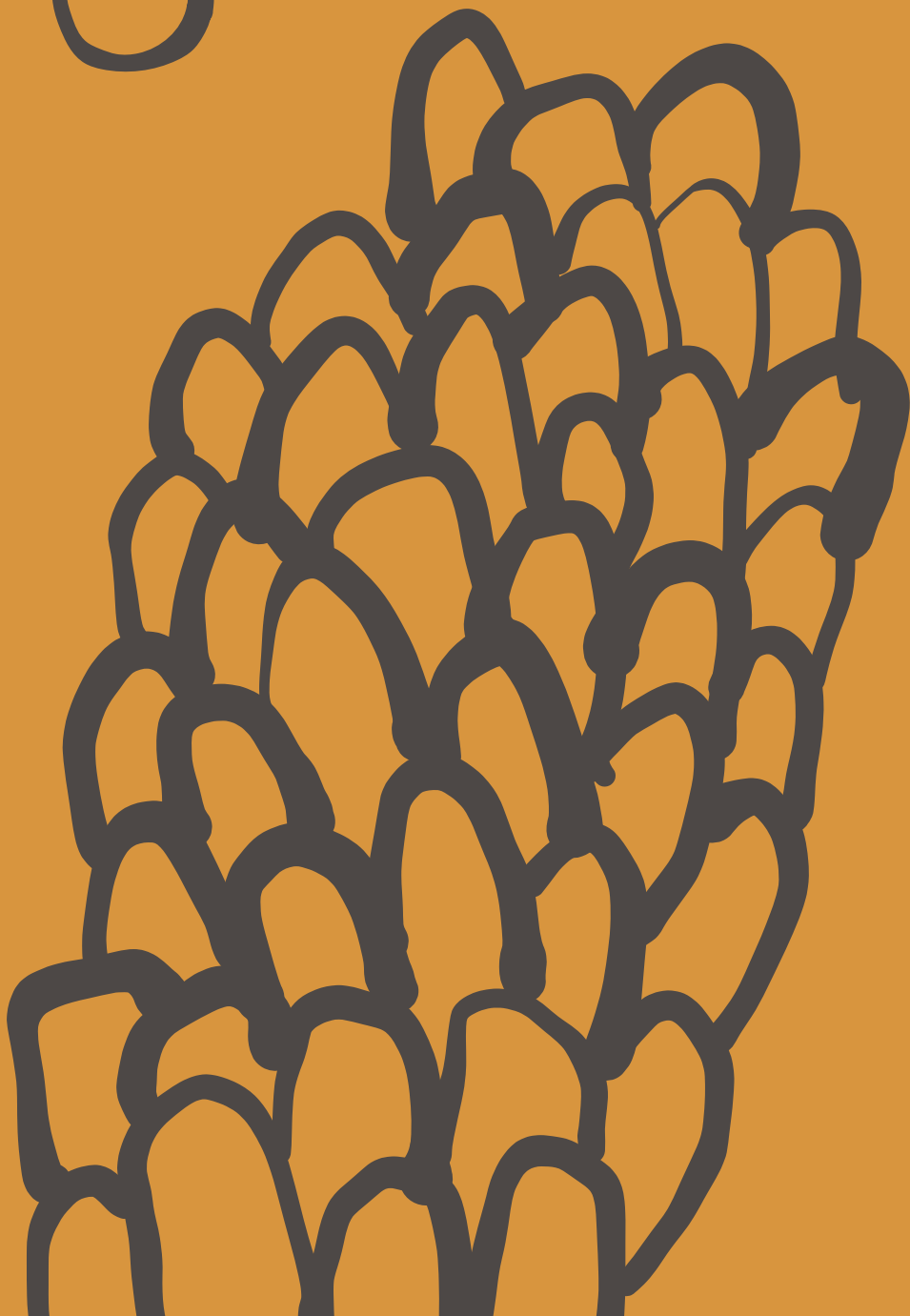
—MIKEY BURTON

22

Active cultures

How to build a
team without trust
fall exercises

The good news is that every studio has culture. The bad news is that a lot of these cultures are not healthy, rewarding, or productive.



Culture is very difficult to intentionally create. It's really the net effect of everyone's interactions in the studio. Because of this your culture should feel natural, not applied. If these interactions feel forced or coached as part of some culture initiative, the only thing you're going to get is a steady stream of eye rolling, and if you're unlucky, some sabotage.

WAKE UP:

“I hate when people say ‘I’m living the dream.’ It’s like they don’t have any control. But the thing is, they do have the control. I’m not living the dream. I manifested the dream. I’m a fucking thousandaire. I like doing all the crusty stuff. There’s less heartbreak. People say thank you in a different way. I can’t put a value on that.”

TAKE ONE FOR THE TEAM:

“Nobody loves drafting timelines. People taking on work that they know no one likes but everyone agrees needs to get done really creates a can-do attitude. We’re a small studio. We need to fix our own printers. There are downsides to working at a small studio for sure but there are a ton of creative advantages and it’s easy to grow and get your work out there.”

—JEFF PERKY, PERKY BROS.

To have a cohesive culture you need to be comfortable with your identity and your studio’s identity. It’s fine if you’re not a studio where everyone goes out for beer after work. It’s fine if your studio’s culture is mostly online because your team is decentralized. It’s even OK if there’s some level of confrontation in your studio as long as it’s coming from a place of caring about the work and people aren’t taking it personally. There’s no ideal here. It just needs to feel good for the people involved. Lead by example — keep the studio focused on your collective goals, treat your employees well, and see what happens.

This will take time. Culture is a process in and of itself. Forcing it will inevitably make it worse. If there are aspects of your culture that you would like to change, think about it environmentally.

FIND YOUR HAPPY PLACE:

“Happiness is very important. I think that’s why we’re 10 years old now. We’re in a good agency and we’re happy with our work. We cook pasta. Different people have different lives. Everyone has their own life and that’s good. During our time, we try to keep harmony. When you’re not doing it’s not mathematics. You need a good environment where everyone is happy. Designers can be fragile. They’re not a designer. It’s not a formula. It’s sensitive to what’s going on. The work makes people feel good. Hard rules so you need to be flexible. Interacting with the people

ant in my company. This is
v, because this is a happy
working here. On Mondays
people cook for the team.
e outside the office and
e in the studio, we try
ou work with designers,
need to create an
one can say how they feel.
This is what it takes to be
la. Designers need to be
n around them and how
el. There aren't a lot of
be sensitive to how you're
e around you."

-VERÓNICA FUERTE, HEY STUDIO

STEP OUTSIDE:

“Typography is about details. It’s often a monastic activity. I’m sure there’s a bit of that in us but it’s important to be well-rounded people. We’re not doing this 24 hours a day.”

—PAUL BARNES, COMMERCIAL TYPE

How can you create an environment where the changes you’re looking for will occur on their own? If people are overworked, give them a few extra vacation days or shorten your hours on Fridays during the summer. Saying, “Hey, you’re working too hard. Take it easy” won’t get the job done. If people are overly critical of clients (something that happens too much in many creative studios), tell them that a portion of their promotion or compensation is dependent on client feedback.

The important thing here is recognition. In order to make these changes, you first need to recognize what needs to change. This means keeping your ear to the ground. Get lunch or coffee or drinks with individuals and groups of people in your studio so you have a sense for what’s going on in their lives. Don’t tell yourself, “If something’s important to someone, they’ll bring it up.” You’re not trying to be friends with everyone here but if you’re going to get a sense for how to improve the culture of your studio you need to feel confident you know how people are feeling.

If your studio gets bigger you need to focus in on the aspects of your culture that you believe are most important to the studio. This is because your direct impact lessens as the team grows bigger. You can't (and shouldn't) be in every meeting and on every call. As your company grows it should also become more diverse: more backgrounds, more specializations, more opinions. This diversity is great in many ways but you need to keep an eye out for which aspects of your culture are most essential for everyone to understand and value. Hiring will become your main way of reinforcing culture. While new people will always bring something different to the table, their relationship to, and effect on, the studio as a whole is just as important. This is a team game. Treat it as such.

LET PEOPLE IN:

“We really like to have friends and designers on press with us. We can educate them on all of the processes that affect the outcome. Sharing is really important. On one hand, it's important to focus on the craft but it's also important to bring people in and reward their interest. There's a balance to strike there.”

—JENNY PAN, THE WEEKEND PRESS

23

We're not done here

Every day you're hustlin'

OK, we've made it to the end. But this is really just the end of the beginning.



Here's a short list of books to get your continued education on track. I have implemented strategies and techniques from every one of these books. But as I said before, if it's easier for you to learn via podcasts or other media, go for it. Just find a way to always be learning.

Built to Sell

by John Warrillow (Portfolio, 2010)

Deep Work

by Cal Newport (Grand Central, 2016)

How to Win Friends and Influence People

by Dale Carnegie (Simon & Schuster, 1936)

How to Write an Email

by Justin Kerr (ExtraCurricular Press, 2015)

Managing the Professional Service Firm

by David H. Maister (Simon & Schuster, 1993)

The E-Myth Revisited

by Michael Gerber (Ballinger, 1985)

The Five Dysfunctions of a Team

by Patrick Lencioni (Jossey-Bass, 2002)

Think critically about your studio and how it could improve. Maybe it's hiring or pricing or competition. There are multiple good books

and other resources specifically about each of these things. All it takes is the desire to improve and the motivation to implement what you learn. As you build your skills, your business will grow and you will figure out ways to free up your time for the work that you truly want to be doing.

Do me a small favor. Thank you for picking up *Run Studio Run*. I hope the book helps you take greater control of your business and spend more time doing the work you're truly great at. While I have you here, there's one more favor I'd like to ask of you:

Please share and review this book.

Here are a few ways how:

Share the book with a friend. I don't care if they buy it but hopefully you get it back some day.

Rate and review the book on Amazon and Goodreads.

Share your thoughts, insights, and successes from the book on Twitter and Instagram with [#runstudiorun](#)

Tell me what you learned or what you'd like to see in the second edition [@elialtman](#) on Twitter

Now go to Mervyn's, buy some pleated slacks, and become the best damn business person you can be.

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Eli Altman is Creative Director at the Berkeley, California-based naming and branding company A Hundred Monkeys. He joined the company in 2009 and became creative director in 2012. He has led projects for many big companies like Google, Samsung, and Target — as well as a wide variety of bars, restaurants, and startups. Before joining A Hundred Monkeys, Eli worked at MetaDesign and Factor Design in San Francisco. Eli has been interviewed on naming and branding with *The New York Times*, NPR, *The Guardian*, *Inc.*, and 99% Invisible.

Eli has released two editions of his naming workbook, *Don't Call It That*, with ExtraCurricular press in 2014 and 2016. The book has been featured in *The New York Times*, *Slate*, and *The Globe and Mail*.

If the stars align you might find Eli sitting outside Cole Coffee in Oakland or running around the East Bay Regional Parks with his goofy Doberman, Davis.

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